



Security personnel stop a Cockroach Janata Party (CJP) supporter near Jantar Mantar during a protest march, in New Delhi, on Monday

PTI

WANGCHUK SLAMS 'BRUTALITY' ON PROTESTERS, TO CONTINUE FAST

AIMAN FATIMA

NEW DELHI: Environmentalist and activist Sonam Wangchuk on Monday announced that he will continue his indefinite hunger strike, saying the police action against protesters during the Cockroach Janta Party's (CJP) "Sansad Chalo" march had strengthened his resolve. In a handwritten statement from Safdarjung Hospital, Wangchuk said he would not end his fast until youth leaders are allowed to meet parliamentarians or he is permitted to do so from the hospital. "Seeing the brutality with which peacefully protesting youth are being dealt with, I have decided to continue my fast until the youth leaders are allowed to meet the parliamentarians at the Sansad Bhawan or I am allowed to meet them here at the hospital. Hopefully, the government will fix accountability for the education minister before that," Wangchuk said. He said he was "touched and moved" by the way protesters had



"I APPEAL TO THE GOVERNMENT AND THE POLICE FORCE TO RESOLVE THE ISSUE BY SIMPLY ALLOWING THE STUDENTS TO PRESENT THEIR GRIEVANCES BEFORE PARLIAMENT TODAY OR TOMORROW"

maintained peace despite "provocation" and appealed to the government to allow students to present their grievances before Parliament. "I appeal to the government and the police force to resolve the issue by simply allowing the students to present their grievances **Continued on P4**

SEE ON P3

RAIN, tear gas and resolve: Inside CJP's march

SONAM Wangchuk's wife moves High Court, appeals against Sunday's order

COURT'S concern is to 'save' Wangchuk's life

AAP hits out at Centre for using tear gas

AMID chaos, one protester's 'maaro sir' cry goes viral

ANNA Hazare, Nirbhaya, CAA, farmers & CJP: Demonstrations that shaped the nat'l Capital



Batons and breakthrough

CJP'S 'CHALO SANSAD' MARCH ERUPTS INTO CLASHES; PROTESTERS STOPPED NEAR PARLIAMENT; TEAR GAS, LATHI-CHARGE MARK TENSE DAY

AIMAN FATIMA

NEW DELHI: What began as a peaceful protest march by thousands of citizens, including students, teachers, parents, job aspirants and professionals, demanding accountability over the alleged NEET-UG 2026 paper leak turned into one of the biggest confrontations witnessed in the Capital in recent years.

As Parliament's Monsoon Session commenced on Monday, central Delhi remained under an unprecedented security blanket as the Cockroach Janta Party's (CJP) "Chalo Sansad" march was stopped before reaching Parliament, triggering clashes, tear gas shelling, lathi-charge and detentions across several locations.

Thousands gathered at Jantar Mantar braving rain and

CLOSER LOOK

» Protesters demanded Dharmendra Pradhan's resignation and exam reforms

» Over 5,000 police personnel secured central Delhi

» Metro stations closed; mobile internet was suspended

» **AROUND 100 PROTESTERS WERE DETAINED**

» More than 50 people, including police, were injured

» Protesters alleged excessive force and injuries



prohibitory orders before marching through Connaught Place, Janpath and Sansad Marg leading towards the Parliament complex. Delhi Police had earlier clarified that no permission had been granted for the procession and had deployed over 5,000 police and paramilitary personnel, along with more than 25 battalions of the Central **Continued on P4**

Delhi Police deny use of excess force and assault claims

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: Delhi Police on Monday rejected allegations of excessive force during the Cockroach Janta Party's (CJP) "Sansad Chalo" march, saying its personnel acted only after protesters turned "unruly, aggres-

sive and violent" and attempted to breach security arrangements around Parliament during the Monsoon Session.

In a statement, the police described social media claims of indiscriminate violence and arbitrary detentions as "incorrect and misleading". It

said protesters tried to push through barricades near Parliament, forcing security personnel to intervene to prevent any breach of law and order. According to the police, several personnel were injured during the confrontation. **Continued on P4**

Centre opens talks, CJP holds ground with three key demands

CJP seeks Wangchuk's release, Dharmendra Pradhan's removal and Rs 1 crore compensation for families of NEET aspirants

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Cockroach Janta Party's (CJP) ongoing agitation over the alleged NEET-UG 2026 paper leak entered a new phase on Monday as the outfit opened direct talks with the Centre, presenting a three-point charter of demands to Union Health Minister J P Nadda while making it clear that the protest would continue until concrete action is taken.

The meeting came amid heightened tensions in the Capital after thousands of CJP supporters attempting to march to Parliament were stopped by Delhi police, with security personnel using



Union Minister JP Nadda, left, meets Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) spokespersons Saurav Das and Ashutosh Ranka, in New Delhi

PTI

barricades, tear gas and lathi charge to prevent protesters from reaching the Parliament complex.

A delegation, led by CJP representatives Ashutosh Ranka and Sourav Das, met

Nadda at his residence and submitted a three-point memorandum seeking the unconditional release of climate activist Sonam Wangchuk, the resignation or sacking of Union **Continued on P4**

Quick News

NO PROPOSAL TO SCRAP LONG TERM CAPITAL GAINS TAX

NEW DELHI: The government is not considering any proposal to scrap the 12.5 per cent Long Term Capital Gains (LTCG) tax for domestic or retail investors, Minister of State for Finance Pankaj Chaudhary told the Lok Sabha on Monday. He said tax policies are reviewed during the annual Budget process. Chaudhary said the recent Income Tax (Amendment) Ordinance, 2026 exempts foreign portfolio investors from tax on interest and capital gains from government securities, effective April 1, 2026, to attract long-term global capital. **See P9**

BURNHAM BECOMES UK'S SEVENTH PM IN 10 YEARS

LONDON: Andy Burnham on Monday became the UK's new Prime Minister after meeting King Charles III, following Keir Starmer's resignation. In his first speech outside 10 Downing Street, Burnham called his leadership a "circuit breaker" and promised a "new political model and a new economic model". Britain's seventh Prime Minister in 10 years, Burnham pledged to end rough sleeping by building more homes, restore stability through a 10-year plan, and make politics "more about problem-solving than point-scoring". **See P8**

DCGI CLEARS INDIA'S FIRST DENGUE VACCINE QDENG

NEW DELHI: India has approved its first vaccine to prevent dengue, with the Drug Controller General of India (DCGI) granting market authorisation to Takeda Biopharmaceuticals India Pvt Ltd for QDENG (TAK-003). The approval gives the country its first licensed vaccine against a disease that places millions at risk every year and accounts for nearly one-third of the global dengue burden. Health experts say the vaccine could become an important addition to India's dengue prevention efforts, alongside mosquito control, surveillance, early diagnosis and public awareness. **Continued on P4**

Simple case of crime, don't politicise it, says SC on Ram Temple donation 'theft' row

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Monday said the alleged embezzlement of donations at the Ram temple in Ayodhya was a criminal matter that should not be turned into a political issue, while asking the Uttar Pradesh government to clarify whether a Special Investigation Team (SIT) could take over the main investigation instead of the local police. The court said its concern was to ensure a fair and proper probe as it heard petitions seeking a court-monitored investigation, a CBI inquiry, a forensic audit and a Comptroller and Auditor General (CAG) audit of the finances of

the Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust.

A bench comprising Chief Justice of India Surya Kant and Justices Joy-malya Bagchi and V Mohana told the parties, "It is a simple case of commission of crime. We are only here to ensure a proper investigation. Courts are not a place for politics."

Solicitor General Tushar Mehta, appearing for the Uttar Pradesh government, informed the court that a status report had been filed and the investigation was progressing. He said eight people had been arrested but declined to disclose further details as the probe was ongoing.

Mehta told the bench that the SIT had initially **Continued on P4**

Four Indians killed in attack on merchant ship leaving Ukrainian port

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: Four Indian nationals were killed and another was critically injured after a merchant vessel came under attack while departing Ukraine's Odesa port, the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) said on Monday.

According to the MEA, the vessel, MV Golden Leo, was attacked on the evening of July 19. The ship had 17 crew members on board, including five Indian nationals. While four Indians died in the incident, the fifth crew member is undergoing treatment in hospital in critical condition.

The ministry said the Indian mission in Ukraine is closely monitoring the situation and is making every effort to provide assistance to those affected.

"We extend our deepest condolences to the families of the deceased **Continued on P4**

Opposition halts Parliament over NEET on opening day

VINAY KUMAR

NEW DELHI: Opposition protests over the alleged NEET-UG 2026 paper leak disrupted the opening day of the Monsoon session of Parliament on Monday, with repeated adjournments in both Houses as members demanded a discussion on the issue. Outside Parliament, thousands of protesters led by the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) clashed with security personnel while attempting to march towards the Parliament complex, demanding the resignation of Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan.

The Lok Sabha was adjourned six times before being called off for the day around 3 pm, while the Rajya

Sabha witnessed five adjournments. Opposition MPs raised slogans, displayed placards and sought discussions on the alleged examination irregularities as well as claims of donation theft linked to the Ram temple.

In the Rajya Sabha, Leader of Opposition Mallikarjun Kharge said the alleged paper leak affected the future of lakhs of students. Referring to the protests at Jantar Mantar, he said, "Thousands of students have reached Jantar Mantar, and they were lathi-charged. The government is trying to browbeat them and suppress the issue." Opposition members responded with slogans of "shame, shame". DMK MPs also protested over the Tamil Nadu-Karnataka water dispute. **Continued on P4**

One 'Ferran-tastic' strike conquers the world

Torres' 106th-minute strike seals Spain's 1-0 win over Argentina

DAMAN SINGH

NEW DELHI: Ferran Torres wore every emotion imaginable on his face: disbelief, sheer relief, a flash of fury, and finally, pure, unbridled joy. For a split second, it seemed even he struggled to comprehend what he had just done.

The breakthrough had arrived from nowhere. Pedro Porro's looping cross hung invitingly in the air before Nico Williams, arriving unnoticed at the back post, headed it into Torres' path. His rasping shot sent MetLife Stadium into delirium.

In the 106th minute, Spain finally had the goal that made



them world champions once again.

For almost two hours, it had looked as though this final would

drift towards the lottery of penalties. Spain had dominated possession but struggled to create, while Argentina were content to defend



Spain are now unbeaten in their last 38 matches — the longest such streak by any European men's team ever

deep, disrupt the rhythm and wait for opportunities that rarely came. Torres' strike, Spain's 20th attempt of the evening, finally set-

tled a contest that had been rich in tension but desperately short on quality.

Every World Cup final leaves behind its defining image. Marco Tardelli's unforgettable celebration in 1982. Fabio Grosso's raw, sobbing run in 2006. Andrés Iniesta peeling off his shirt after his extra-time winner in Johannesburg. For Torres, overwhelmed by the weight of the moment, the celebration was instinctive. He ripped a corner flag from the turf before disappearing beneath a sea of red shirts.

"I think the goal belonged to all 47 million Spaniards," Torres said later, his **Continued on P4**

Tripura DGP found hanging at police headquarters

TARUN CHAKRABORTY

AGARTALA: The death of Tripura Director General of Police (DGP) Anurag Dhankar on Monday sent shockwaves across the state, with the circumstances surrounding his demise remaining unclear. According to Tripura Police sources, Dhankar was found hanging in his chamber at the Police Headquarters (PHQ) on Monday morning. However, neither the state government nor the Tripura Police had officially confirmed the cause of death at the time of filing this report. **Continued on P4**

'FLOOD-HIT LOCATIONS SHRINK'

L-G and CM review flood control, disaster response

AIMAN FATIMA & SHIVANGI SHUKLA

NEW DELHI: Delhi Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu and Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Monday chaired a meeting of the Delhi Disaster Management Authority (DDMA) to review preparedness for heavy rainfall, progress of the Urban Flood Mitigation Plan and the establishment of the State Disaster Response Force (SDRF) in the Capital amid evolving El-Nino conditions and erratic monsoons. The meeting noted an improvement in Delhi's flooding situation, with waterlogging-prone sites reducing from 194 in 2024 to 169 in 2025 and further to just 34 in 2026. Repeated waterlogging sites also declined from 53 between 2024-25 to only eight



The meeting noted an improvement in Delhi's flooding situation

FILE IMAGE

between 2025-26.

Officials informed that MCD, I&FCD, NDMC and DDA had completed their desilting targets, while PWD achieved about 95 per cent and Delhi Jal Board reported over 85 per cent desilting across its sewer network. The Chief Minister directed timely disposal of removed silt, immediate covering of drains and manholes, and zero tolerance towards accidents. The meeting also discussed the preventive removal of dangerous trees that often fall during storms or heavy rainfall, with directions for proactive identification and removal.

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CLOSER LOOK

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heavy rainfall, the LG directed all departments to ensure minimum or no flooding and stressed that accountability for lapses would be fixed. He said flooding remained a legacy issue but directed officials to implement all short-term measures even as long-term drainage projects progress.

The L-G also directed that the SDRF be made operational at the earliest with enhanced strength and emphasised seamless coordination among agencies during emergencies.

The L-G and CM instructed departments to resolve flooding and accident-related issues without jurisdictional delays, ensure real-time monitoring of public complaints, keep mobile heavy-duty pumps ready during crises, and strengthen coordination with neighbouring states for an effective flood response.

At the meeting, the L-G and the Chief Minister observed that while Delhi had witnessed significant improvement in flooding compared to 2024 and 2025, there was still considerable scope for further improvement.

Citing weather forecasts indicating spells of sudden

Delhi clears PARIVARTAN vehicle scrappage scheme

AIMAN FATIMA

NEW DELHI: The Delhi government has approved the implementation of the Centre's PARIVARTAN (Programme for Accelerated Renewal and Incentivisation of Vehicle Assets for Reducing Transport Air Pollution and Network Emissions) scheme, aimed at replacing old, polluting commercial vehicles with BS-VI and electric alternatives across Delhi-NCR.

The scheme is being implemented simultaneously across the Delhi-NCR region. Under the scheme, the state government in which a commercial vehicle is registered will provide the incentives and concessions applicable to that vehicle.

The proposal was cleared by the Delhi Cabinet, with Chief Minister Rekha Gupta describing it as a major step towards reducing vehicular pollution and strengthening the capital's clean transport network.

Under the scheme, owners of BS-IV and older light goods vehicles (LGVs) who



The scheme also covers BS-IV and older buses, which can be replaced only with BS-VI CNG or electric buses

scrap their vehicles and purchase new electric LGVs will receive a 100 per cent exemption on motor vehicle tax and registration fees for 10 years, along with a 5 per cent interest subvention, an 8 per cent manufacturer (OEM) discount and fuel vouchers or an equivalent one-time benefit. Those opting for used electric LGVs will receive a 50 per cent tax

exemption for 10 years, interest support and the fuel voucher benefit. Similar incentives have been extended to medium and heavy goods vehicles (MGVs and HGVs). Owners replacing old vehicles with new BS-VI, higher-emission-standard or electric models will get full exemption from motor vehicle tax and registration fees for a decade, while buyers of used eligible vehicles will receive a 50 per cent tax exemption.

The scheme also covers BS-IV and older buses, which can be replaced only with BS-VI CNG or electric buses. Beneficiaries will also receive relief from road tax and fitness penalties pending for over a year. Additionally, eligible BS-IV vehicles may be sold in non-NCAP cities outside the NCR instead of being scrapped.

The government estimates around 2.07 lakh truck and bus owners will benefit from the scheme, which will be implemented through a dedicated digital portal developed by the Ministry of Road Transport and Highways.

Delhi Police arrest two Nandu gang members

PRAJYOT DEOGHARE

NEW DELHI: Two alleged active members of the Kapil Sangwan alias Nandu gang were arrested by the Delhi Police following a brief exchange of fire in Tikri Kalan on Saturday, officials said.

The accused were identified as Rohit alias Cheera (24), a resident of Narela, and Praveen alias Pinki (30), a resident of Sangam Vihar. According to the police, both were wanted in a firing case registered at Bahadurgarh City police station in Haryana's Jhajjar district, with a reward of Rs 50,000 announced on each.

Police said the Special Staff of the Outer district received specific intelligence that the two gang members would arrive on PVC Road in Tikri Kalan to meet an associate while carrying illegal firearms. Acting on the information, a team led by Inspector Rohit, under the supervision of ACP (Operations) Virender Dalal, laid a trap at the spot.

When the suspects were intercepted and asked to surrender, they allegedly opened fire on the police team in an attempt to flee. The police retaliated in self-defence, resulting in a brief exchange of fire. During the encounter, two bullets

struck the bulletproof jackets of constables Anuj and Harkesh, who escaped unhurt. Both accused sustained bullet injuries to their legs before being overpowered.

Police recovered two semi-automatic pistols, three live cartridges, four empty cartridges and a stolen motorcycle. A case has been registered at Mundka police station under the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita and the Arms Act. Investigators also found that Rohit was a parole absconder in a 2022 case registered at Narela police station. Police said Praveen is allegedly involved in six criminal cases and Rohit in four.

DDA unveils lifetime membership for Dwarka golf course from Jul 21

SHIVANGI SHUKLA

NEW DELHI: On the directions of Delhi Lieutenant Governor Sardar Taranjit Singh Sandhu, the Delhi Development Authority (DDA) will open online registration for lifetime membership of its 18-hole championship golf course in Dwarka Sector 24 from July 21 for a period of two months. The golf course, inaugurated in 2024, has so far offered only three-year and five-year tenure memberships.

Spread across 158 acres and measuring 7,377 yards, the 18-hole championship course

Membership fee has been fixed at Rs 3.50 lakh for the Govt category and Rs 7.50 lakh for the Non-Govt category: Officials

will offer 850 lifetime memberships, including 250 under the Government category and 600 under the Non-Government category. Golfers will also continue to have the option of three-year and five-year tenure memberships.

The lifetime membership fee has been fixed at Rs 3.50 lakh for the Government category and Rs 7.50 lakh for the Non-Government category.

Three-year memberships are priced at Rs 1.20 lakh and Rs 2.50 lakh respectively, while five-year memberships cost Rs 1.80 lakh and Rs 4.50 lakh.

Applicants must apply online by paying a non-refundable registration fee of Rs 2,500. Following scrutiny, selected applicants will be required to deposit the membership fee online within 30 days of receiving the offer. If

the number of eligible applications exceeds the available memberships, allotment will be made through a computerised draw of lots. Only one application per applicant will be accepted.

The golf course features a 375-yard driving range with 52 bays, North Shore SLT grass fairways, and a clubhouse with a restaurant, cafeteria, conference hall, lecture hall, pro shop, equipment fitting studio, swimming pool, sauna and steam facilities. The facility includes a golf academy, automated irrigation, drainage and rainwater recharge systems.

Delhi forms panel to probe GTB Hosp fan incident after patient dies

NEW DELHI: Delhi Health Minister Pankaj Kumar Singh directed officials on Monday to constitute a committee to investigate the death of a patient at Guru Teg Bahadur (GTB) Hospital after a ceiling fan allegedly fell on him.

The minister said strict departmental action would be taken if negligence is found.

The direction came a day after a 42-year-old patient died around three hours after a ceiling fan allegedly fell on him inside the hospital's emergency ward, prompting his family to demand an enquiry into the incident.

During a high-level review meeting with senior Health Department officials, the minister learned that a committee headed by the Special Secretary (Health) had been constituted to investigate the incident and was asked to submit its report within three days. According to the Health Department, appropriate and strict departmental action will be taken based on the committee's findings, reiterating that negligence in healthcare services will not be tolerated. Delhi Health Minister Pankaj Singh reviewed monsoon preparedness, directing hospitals to ensure adequate medicines, diagnostics, staffing and readiness for seasonal diseases, while the hospital said the patient's death was unrelated.

MP05T

Class 11 student fatally stabbed in south Delhi

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: A 19-year-old class 11 student was allegedly stabbed to death following a quarrel with a group of people in southeast Delhi's Kalkaji area on Sunday afternoon, police said.

The incident occurred near a park in B Block of DDA Flats in Kalkaji, they said.

According to police, a PCR call regarding a quarrel among school students was received at 2.23 pm. A police team rushed to the spot and found the victim lying with stab injuries.

A CATS ambulance also reached the spot and administered cardiopulmonary resuscitation (CPR) before shifting the injured to the AIIMS Trauma Centre, where doctors declared him dead, police said.

The deceased was identified as Saiyed Husain (19), a resident of JJ Camp, Okhla Phase-II. "He was a class 11 student studying at an MCD school in Kalkaji. Preliminary investigation has revealed that Husain was stabbed during a quarrel involving two or three persons," a senior police officer said.

Police said the suspected attackers have been identified and multiple teams have been formed to trace and apprehend them.

"The accused have been identified. Efforts are being made to trace and apprehend them at the earliest," a police officer said.

Police said that a case has been registered and further investigation into the matter is underway. They are examining CCTV camera footage from the area and questioning witnesses to ascertain the sequence of events leading to the attack.

The exact motive behind the incident is yet to be established. The body has been sent for postmortem.

Drunk husband kills wife over dinner dispute in Ggm: Police

OUR CORRESPONDENT

GURUGRAM: An intoxicated man allegedly killed his wife following a dispute over cooking dinner in Gurugram, police said on Monday.

The accused husband initially misled the police by claiming his wife died from excessive alcohol consumption, but the police arrested him after the post-mortem report revealed she had been strangled to death, they added.

According to the police, a woman, identified as Talmai, was found dead on July 16 in the shanties located near the Badshahpur vegetable market. After receiving the information, the police arrived at the scene, took possession of the body, and sent it for a post-mortem.

Her husband, Dinesh, told the police that he and his wife used to consume alcohol, and on the day of the incident, his wife had consumed an excessive amount, leading to her death.



Initially, the police started

investigating the matter and awaited the post-mortem report, they said.

A senior investigating officer said that the post-mortem report revealed the woman died due to strangulation and suffocation. Subsequently, the police detained Dinesh.

During questioning, he admitted that on the day of the incident, an argument broke out between the couple over cooking while he was under the influence of alcohol and as the dispute escalated, he strangled his wife to death.

Police arrested Dinesh, a Lucknow native living in Badshahpur, and said further investigation is underway.

Police destroys 1,450 kg narcotics

NEW DELHI: The Delhi Police on Monday destroyed 1,452 kg of seized narcotic drugs valued at Rs 897 crore in the international market, an official said.

According to the police, the 10th mega drug destruction programme was conducted at a waste disposal facility on GT Karnal Road in the presence of Special Commissioner of Police (Crime) H G S Dhalwal and other senior officers.

The destroyed contraband included around 1,010 kg of methamphetamine, 135 kg of heroin, 62 kg of charas, 37 kg of ganja, 16 kg of methaqualone, 91 kg of poppy straw, 70 kg of phenylpropanone, more than 15 lakh tramadol tablets, over 36,000 bottles of codeine syrup and other psychotropic substances seized in various cases, the police said. With the latest destruction, the Delhi Police has disposed of around 49,663 kg of narcotics worth an estimated Rs 14,799 crore in the international market through 10 such drives conducted since December 2022, they said.

Dhalwal said the exercise aimed to dismantle the narcotics trafficking ecosystem, not just destroy seized drugs.

Greater Noida to widen DMIC link road for ₹25.63 cr

DIPIKA KIROLA

GREATER NOIDA: The Greater Noida Authority has initiated the process to widen the 2.5-km road connecting Dada Roundabout to the Delhi-Mumbai Industrial Corridor (DMIC) Integrated Industrial Township from four lanes to six. The authority has floated a tender for the project, estimated to cost Rs 25.63 crore.

Officials said the road widening is part of a broader plan to improve traffic flow and strengthen connectivity to key industrial and infrastructure projects. The upgraded road will provide smoother access to the DMIC township, Noida International Airport at Jewar and the proposed Multimodal Transport and Logistics Hub, benefiting both commuters and freight traffic.

Senior Manager (Projects) Satish Yadav said the project will also include footpaths on



a resident of Nagpur, lying dead on the bed. The man, identified as Anmol Kunda Patil (30), son of Gundu Patil and a resident of Maharashtra, was found hanging from the ceiling fan with a nylon rope.

The Delhi Police Crime Team and the Forensic Science Laboratory (FSL) inspected the scene and collected evidence. During the examination,

investigators recovered a suicide note which, prima facie, appears to have been written by the deceased man. Police said its contents are being examined as part of the investigation.

Both bodies have been shifted to AIIMS for post-mortem examination to ascertain the exact cause of death. The families of both deceased persons have been informed.

Police said further inquiry is underway to establish the circumstances leading to the deaths. While initial findings point to suicide, investigators are examining all possible angles before reaching a final conclusion.

REVIEW TO ASSESS CAPACITY

DU mulls 1-yr PG expansion

ANAMTA FATIMA

NEW DELHI: Delhi University has constituted a six-member committee to examine the feasibility of increasing the admission intake for its One-Year Postgraduate (PG) Programme introduced under the National Education Policy (NEP) 2020.

According to the University, the committee will assess factors including student demand, availability of faculty, classroom infrastructure and other academic resources before making its recommendations. The review is aimed at ensuring that any increase in seats does not compromise the quality of teaching and learning.

The One-Year PG Programme, introduced under NEP 2020, is intended primarily for eligible students who have completed a four-year undergraduate degree.

With growing interest in the programme, the University is evaluating whether additional seats can be accommodated in future admission



cycles while maintaining academic standards and institutional capacity.

University officials have clarified that no decision has been taken to increase the number of seats at present.

The six-member committee has only been constituted to study the matter and submit its recommendations. Any proposal to revise the intake will be considered only after the panel's report is reviewed and approved by the competent authorities.

Delhi University advised One-Year PG aspirants not to rely on speculation over seat enhancement and urged them to follow only official notifications for updates on intake, eligibility and other admission-related decisions.

DAY-LONG CONFRONTATION SHUT METRO STATIONS, SNARLED TRAFFIC AND LEFT SCORES INJURED

Rain, tear gas and resolve: Inside CJP’s march

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Protesters carrying flags, some dressed as cockroaches, marched on as police fired tear gas and wielded sticks to stop them. Every time they were pushed back, they regrouped and tried again. By afternoon, the high-security roads leading to Parliament had turned into a battleground of slogan-shouting, rain and tear gas.

The smell of tear gas lingered in the air, rent by cries to march on. They came from almost every corner of the country and deployed every ruse to be a part.

The mix had teenagers bunking school, parents marching with their children, college students beside government job aspirants, and small-townners with city folks. A few children came dressed as cockroaches; quite a number were seen as ‘Mahatma Gandhi’.

They had all gathered in Delhi for the Cockroach Janta Party’s (CJP) ‘Chalo Sansad’ march, demanding the resignation of Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan, who presided over a fiasco-ridden



MP Chandrashekar Azad Ravan, Gitanjali J Angmo and CJP founder Abhijeet Dipke during the march PIC/PTI

NEET earlier in the year. The march began from Jantar Mantar, where the CJP has been holding a sit-in since June 20, and coincided with the opening day of the Monsoon Session of Parliament. It also came as educationist Sonam Wangchuk remained hospitalised. By morning, streams of protesters had begun moving

towards Parliament carrying the national flag and handwritten placards.

Many arrived after overnight journeys by train and bus and still carried backpacks on their shoulders. Roads echoed with chants of “Bharat Mata Ki Jai”, “Vande Mata-ram”, “Inquilab Zindabad” and “Dharmendra Pradhan Istifa Do”. Every road leading towards

Parliament was blocked.

Police in riot gear stood behind several layers of metal barricades. Buses were kept ready to detain protesters, while emergency vehicles waited nearby.

Unable to move through the main roads, many protesters slipped into narrow lanes, looking for another way to reach Parliament. Some tried

TAKEAWAYS

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- » A few children came dressed as cockroaches; quite a few were seen as ‘Mahatma Gandhi’
- » Every road leading towards Parliament was blocked. Police in riot gear stood behind several layers of metal barricades



A security officer fires a teargas shell to disperse a march towards the Parliament, in New Delhi PIC/PTI

CJP protest and Parl session choke traffic in central Delhi

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Traffic at several stretches of central Delhi crawled on Monday, with commuters stuck for hours while covering just a few kilometres as the Cockroach Janata Party staged a protest and Parliament’s Monsoon Session began.

This comes as thousands of protesters gathered near Parliament Street here and tried to march towards Parliament to demand accountability over alleged examination irregularities and the resignation of Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan, braving lathicharge by security personnel. Several roads in and around New Delhi experienced heavy traffic, with commuters reporting prolonged delays and slow-moving vehicles.

The traffic situation further slowed down as the Monsoon Session of the Lok Sabha and Rajya Sabha also began on Monday, prompting increased vehicular movement and traffic restrictions in the New Delhi range. “I was stuck in the traffic for at least three hours while moving from Krishna Menon Marg towards Sansad Marg.



This route usually takes barely ten minutes,” a commuter said.

Another commuter said that there was complete chaos on the road as several routes were completely blocked and office goers were left in limbo.

“This much police and security deployment is unusual in this area. I had to drive on the wrong side of the road to reach the office. I am late by at least 1.5 hours,” an office commuter who works in the NITI Ayog building said.

The Delhi Traffic Police had earlier issued an advisory asking commuters to avoid several roads and junctions in the area as far as possible.

Rafi Marg, Motilal Nehru Marg, Maulana Azad Road, K Kamaraj Marg, Raisina Road, Rajendra Prasad Road, Parliament Street, Ashoka Road,

Talkatora Road, Pandit Pant Marg, Rakab Ganj Gurudwara Road, Vikas Marg, DDU Marg and Minto Road were among the stretches listed as roads to be avoided.

The advisory also mentioned Vijay Chowk, Boat Club, R/A Rail Bhawan, R/A Sunehri Masjid, R/A Patel Chowk, R/A Boota Singh, R/A Prime Chowk, R/A GRG, R/A Jalebi Chowk, ITO Chowk and Karkari Mor as locations to be avoided.

The traffic police suggested commuters use alternative routes, including Janpath, Man Singh Road, Akbar Road, Teen Murti Marg, Shanti Path, Maulana Abdul Kalam Azad Road, Kamal Atatürk Marg, Panchsheel Marg, Vinay Marg, Outer Circle at Connaught Place, Baba Kharak Singh Marg, R/A RML, Mother Teresa Crescent Road, 11 Murti, Sardar Patel Marg, Mahatma Gandhi Road and DBG Road.

Motorists were advised to remain patient and cooperate with police as violent clashes between protesters and police near Parliament left several injured and caused major traffic disruptions after lathicharge and tear gas were used.

Court’s concern is to ‘save’ Wangchuk’s life

High Court has sought his medical reports, bulletins from Safdarjung

NEW DELHI: The Delhi High Court on Monday asked the Safdarjung Hospital here to file Sonam Wangchuk’s pathological reports and health bulletins and said that it would take a call on Tuesday on the plea by the fasting activist’s wife Gitanjali Angmo to shift him to a private facility.

Asserting that its concern was to “save” Wangchuk’s life, the court asked Solicitor General Tushar Mehta to bring on record a complete compilation of his medical reports.

The bench of Chief Justice D K Upadhyaya and Justice Tejas Karia was hearing an appeal by Angmo against a Sunday order of the high court refusing to interfere with his ongoing treatment at the central government hospital.

“We direct that all pathological reports of the husband of the appellant, based on samples analysed at the labs of Safdarjung and AIIMS and a

private lab, shall be filed on an affidavit sworn by the director of respondent no. 4 (Safdarjung Hospital),” the court ordered.

“It is directed that the respondent no 4, while filing the affidavit, will also bring on record all the medical bulletins issued by it from time to time,” it added. “The report should include today’s sample analysis,” said the bench.

It asked the In-charge director of AIIMS as well as the AIIMS emergency doctor treating Wangchuk to be present at the hearing on Tuesday, and also sought the presence of the doctor who was treating him earlier.

The Delhi High Court reserved its order on Sonam Wangchuk’s plea to shift to a private hospital, observing that saving his life was the foremost priority, while stating that medical decisions should rest with doctors and reports be shared with his family.



People and security personnel gather near an overturned police vehicle during the protest demanding the resignation of Union Edu Min PIC/PTI

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Sonam Wangchuk’s wife Gitanjali J Angmo on Monday moved the Delhi High Court to appeal against an order refusing to interfere with the fasting activist’s ongoing treatment at Safdarjung Hospital.

In her appeal, Angmo contended that the single judge’s Sunday order illegally confines Wangchuk to Safdarjung Hospital without any arrest and effectively directs that neither the activist nor his wife has decisive authority in determining his medical treatment.

The appeal said that the order does not address “informed consent” or one’s



right to accept or reject any medical treatment.

In a special Sunday hearing, Justice Mini Pushkarna had refused to interfere with Wangchuk’s treatment at Safdarjung Hospital here, stating that the government’s removal of the fasting activist from Jantar Mantar to a government hospital cannot be called arbitrary.

The single judge had opined that no interim order



People and security personnel gather near an overturned police vehicle during the protest demanding the resignation of Union Edu Min PIC/PTI

AAP hits out at Centre for using tear gas

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Aam Aadmi Party on Monday slammed the Centre for lobbying tear gas shells on marching protesters and accused it of hubris for not starting a talk with the students on strike for the resignation of Union Minister Dharmendra Pradhan.

AAP Rajya Sabha MP Sanjay Singh said the youth protesting now for several days had only one demand: the removal of Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan.

“The protest has been going on for several days. They had only one demand: resignation of the education minister and strict action in the paper leak matter. But no one from the

‘Students were peacefully marching, but all roads were barricaded around Jantar Mantar, force was used..’: AAP’s Gopal Rai

central government had time to talk to the protestors. Prime Minister Narendra Modi has time to eat ‘Melody’ but not talk to the protestors,” Singh said.

The party’s Rajya Sabha member said youth were beaten up, tear gas was used against them, and they were treated like they were from an enemy country.

“Prime Minister Modi should now understand that the youth has awakened. They will throw you out of power if you do not listen to them,” he said.

Addressing a press conference, AAP leader Gopal Rai demanded that the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) founder Abhijeet Dipke be immediately released from custody.

“They only demanded the removal of Pradhan; what the government did instead was the removal of Sonam Wangchuk from the protest site. Students were peacefully marching, but all roads were barricaded around Jantar Mantar, force was used, and Dipke was arrested,” Rai said. Delhi Police has said Dipke

was never detained and the reports of his detention were false. The press conference was also addressed by Leader of Opposition Atishi and the AAP’s Delhi unit president, Saurabh Bharadwaj, and MLA Sanjeev Jha.

“The huge number of protestors suggests that PM Modi and his government are hugely unpopular with Gen Z. People are still joining the protest; youth not only from Delhi but Uttar Pradesh and Haryana have also joined,” Bharadwaj said. AAP leaders Atishi, Manish Sisodia and Sanjay Singh joined the CJP’s Parliament march as protests over exam irregularities escalated into clashes with police in central Delhi.

FROM INDIA GATE TO PARLIAMENT: THE ROUTES OF PUBLIC DISSENT

Anna Hazare, Nirbhaya, CAA, farmers & CJP: Demonstrations that shaped the nat’l Capital

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: As CJP supporters attempted to march towards Parliament on Monday, leading to clashes with police and detentions, the scenes echoed some of Delhi’s most defining public protests over the past 15 years, when thousands similarly tried to take their demands to the seat of power.

The 2021 Republic Day tractor rally was among the biggest protests to witness a march towards central Delhi. As part of the year-long agitation against the three farm laws, tens of thousands of farmers entered the capital with tractors on January 26 after assembling at the city’s borders.

While the rally had been permitted on designated routes, a section of the protesters breached barricades, deviated from the agreed routes



Nirbhaya protests saw thousands of students, young professionals and citizens gather at India Gate

and headed towards central Delhi, leading to clashes with police. Some protesters also entered the Red Fort complex and hoisted the Nishan Sahib and farmers’ union flags from its ramparts. More than 300 police personnel were injured in the violence.

On Monday, Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) supporters carrying the tricolour raised slogans and pushed through

tests over the years, with demonstrators seeking to press their demands before the government.

The 2011 Anna Hazare-led anti-corruption movement was one of the largest public mobilisations witnessed in the capital. After Hazare’s arrest, thousands gathered outside Tihar Jail before he shifted to Ram Lila Maidan, where his 13-day fast drew large crowds demanding a stronger Lokpal law.

The 2012 Nirbhaya protests saw thousands of students, young professionals and citizens gather at India Gate and Raisina Hill before repeatedly attempting to march towards Parliament and Rashtrapati Bhavan. Police responded with water cannons, tear gas and baton charges to disperse the crowds.

The anti-CAA protests in 2019 and 2020 again saw large demonstrations across Delhi.

Student protests at Jamia Millia Islamia and the prolonged sit-in at Shaheen Bagh drew thousands of people, while road closures, heavy police deployment and temporary Metro station closures became common during the agitation.

The year-long farmers’ protest against the three farm laws also turned Delhi’s borders into major protest sites. Thousands of farmers camped at Singhu, Tikri and Ghazipur after being stopped from entering the city, with the demonstrations continuing until the Centre repealed the laws.

Like the 2023 wrestlers’ march towards Parliament, Monday’s protest drew thousands to central Delhi, becoming the latest major demonstration in the national capital marked by heavy police deployment and attempts to reach Parliament.

Security personnel try to evict Cockroach Janata Party (CJP) supporters during the protest march at Sansad Marg, in New Delhi, on Monday PTI

NEW DELHI: While many dispersed amid the police crackdown in the heart of Delhi on Monday, a protester stood his ground, repeatedly saying “maaro sir, maaro”, not flinching once as the members of the force obliged.

The incident was caught on video during a Parliament march called by the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP), as protesters climbed heavy barricades,

braved lathi-charges, and confronted with tear gas shells.

The viral video showed the man, clad in T-shirt and trousers, standing face-to-face with a group of security personnel armed with lathis, repeatedly saying, “maaro sir, maaro sir (beat me, sir)”

The marchers, a large number of whom were students, were stopped at several points in central Delhi.

CJP protest march: Five Delhi Metro stations shut for hours

NEW DELHI: The Delhi Metro Rail Corporation on Monday closed five of its stations in the central part of the city ahead of a protest march by the Cockroach Janta Party. Rajiv Chowk, Janpath, Patel Chowk, Central Secretariat and Seva Teerth were shut for most of the day, and were later reopened one after another.

Seva Teerth metro station was reopened first, followed by Janpath and Patel Chowk, the corporation said. Some of the gates of the

Rajiv Chowk and Central Secretariat stations remained shut, though people could change trains there.

Services on the Violet Line were also briefly disrupted during the day due to a technical issue before returning to normal.

Delhi was rocked as thousands of students and professionals marched towards Parliament for the resignation of Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan over the NEET fiasco.

From Page 1

Wangchuk slams

before Parliament today or tomorrow. I am sure the young protesters will maintain peace tomorrow as they did today,” he said.

Earlier in the day, Wangchuk had indicated that he would end his fast only if the government accepted accountability for alleged failures in the education system or if political leaders assured him that the issue would be raised during the ongoing Monsoon Session of Parliament. However, after the developments during the march, he decided to continue the protest.

Wangchuk has been admitted to Safdarjung Hospital since July 18 after Delhi Police shifted him there following 21 days of fasting. His supporters have alleged that he is being kept under “illegal detention”, a charge rejected by the authorities.

The CJP is demanding accountability for alleged irregularities in competitive examinations and has sought the resignation of Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan.

Batons and breakthrough

Armed Police Forces (CAPF), across the New Delhi district.

The first confrontation broke out near Jantar Mantar after protesters attempted to breach barricades. Similar clashes followed near Patel Chowk, Constitution Club, Rail Bhawan, Shastri Bhawan, Janpath, Connaught Place and the Reserve Bank of India as demonstrators tried to move towards Parliament. Security personnel responded with repeated lathi-charge, tear gas shells, Vajra anti-riot vehicles, water cannons and rapid action response teams to disperse the protesters.

White clouds of tear gas hung over Parliament House and the insistent chant of slogans from restive young people fighting police batons filled the atmosphere during the protest march. By the end of the day, police managed to vacate Jantar Mantar.

It was an unprecedented Monday of highs and lows as thousands of young and angry people converged near Parliament on the first day of the Monsoon session to push for the resignation of Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan, only to be pushed back by lathis and teargas shells.

‘Chalo Sansad’. That was the rallying cry bringing together the young who transformed the leafy, high-security streets of central Delhi into extraordinary scenes of protests.

Carrying placards and the tricolour, shouting slogans such as “Bharat Mata Ki Jai”, “Jai Bhim”, “Vande Mataram” and “Dharmendra Pradhan Istifa Do”, many just sat where they were stopped, the protests mushrooming in multiple places across the city.

The crowd included school-children, college students, parents and senior citizens. Some came in uniforms, while others wore cockroach costumes.

By evening, police had dismantled the stage, tents and other structures at the month-long protest site while security remained tight across the Parliament complex and Central Vista.

Several protesters also sustained injuries during the police action. One protester, displaying injuries on his body while being escorted away, asked, “Are we animals? Why are we being treated like terrorists?”

Participants claimed many students suffered injuries to their hands, legs and backs, while one protester allegedly sustained a shoulder dislocation. Some also accused male police personnel of using force against women demonstrators.

“We were only protesting peacefully. Suddenly the police started beating us. My hand has been fractured and I have injuries on my back and leg as well,” said an injured protester.

Many demonstrators complained of irritation in their eyes and breathing discomfort after tear gas shells were fired. Protesters remained defiant, saying, “This is not democracy; this is dictatorship. But we are not

going to give up.”

The CJP further alleged that children participating in the protest were injured and claimed that Sonam Wangchuk’s wife, Dr Gitanjali Angmo, was pulled by her hair during the police action. There was no official response on this.

Ahead of the mobilisation, authorities enforced elaborate security arrangements across central Delhi. Janpath, Patel Chowk, Rajiv Chowk, Central Secretariat and Seva Teerth Metro stations were temporarily closed, while commuters reported being stranded inside stations as access was restricted. Protesters also alleged they were briefly confined inside Metro premises and faced difficulty accessing drinking water.

The government suspended mobile internet services in parts of central Delhi till 6 pm. Airtel, Reliance Jio and Vodafone Idea confirmed receiving official directions to suspend services, and subscribers received text messages informing them of the shutdown. The Internet Freedom Foundation criticised the move, saying no suspension order had been made public in accordance with Supreme Court guidelines.

The protest received support from several public figures and celebrities. Veteran actors Shabana Azmi, Prakash Raj and MP Mohua Moitra joined the demonstration and participated in the “Chalo Sansad” march. “We are here to exercise our constitutional right to peaceful protest. Mahatma Gandhi taught us how to protest peacefully,” said Shabana Azmi. She also urged people not to divert attention by questioning why more film personalities had not joined the movement. During the march, Azmi reportedly felt unwell due to the humid conditions and was escorted to a nearby security cabin after experiencing dizziness.

Actor Prakash Raj also extended support to the agitation, while several social media influencers amplified the campaign online. Protest organisers said WhatsApp groups helped coordinate travel and accommodation for people arriving in Delhi from across the country.

The crackdown drew sharp political reactions. Congress leader Rahul Gandhi termed peaceful protest a fundamental right and warned police officials that “The Constitution, not the government, is your master. Power does not last forever. Accountability will certainly be enforced.” In a separate video, he accused the Centre of failing students and urged the government to address their demands instead of using force. Gandhi dubbed Prime Minister Narendra Modi as the “most anti-youth” PM in the country’s history as he accused the government of not just failing the youth but also pouncing on them.

Gandhi said in a post on X, “Prime Minister Modi... is so ‘anti-youth’ that he can’t even take the resignation of a failed Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan.” “152 paper leaks. 7.5 crore students victimised. And not a single guilty person punished. Who got the punishment? The hardworking youth,” he said on X.

AAP leaders joined the protest in solidarity with the demonstrators. Jammu and Kashmir Chief Minister Omar Abdullah, who had arrived in Delhi for the National Conference’s statehood protest, abandoned plans to walk after the area became crowded and instead travelled in an auto-rickshaw, saying his walk “was about to turn into another procession.”

Acting on an appeal from Sonam Wangchuk, Dipke ended his indefinite hunger strike. Several students who had also been fasting in solidarity ended their fast alongside him, though party leaders asserted that the movement itself would continue. Dipke, who took up the fast after Wangchuk was forcibly removed from Jantar Mantar after 21 days of forgoing food, was also picked up from the place.

Dipke and others, including Wangchuk’s wife, Gitanjali Angmo, moved to Kerala House close by, where they continued their sit-in.

Despite the dismantling of the protest site and the heavy police deployment, demonstrators regrouped on nearby roads, reiterating their demands for the resignation of Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan, accountability over the alleged NEET-UG paper leak, examination irregularities and comprehensive reforms in the

examination system.

More than 50 police personnel and protesters were injured during clashes with CJP protesters in New Delhi district on Sunday, prompting a massive security response, police sources said.

Sources added that about 100 people were detained and 65 medico-legal cases registered at the Ram Manohar Lohia Hospital.

Away from celeb and politician speak, the youth, some who had come from other states, gave vent to their angst.

Anshika, 17, lied to her family, telling them she was going to school but headed in the morning to join the march to Parliament. She tried to climb over barricades and was pulled down by women police personnel.

“We did not lie to our families and come here to be picked up and detained like criminals,” Anshika said, showing bruises on her hand. When it is time for elections, they come to our homes and ask for votes. But they did not even come to engage in a dialogue over the NEET paper leak,” she said.

Women from several states, including Bihar, Maharashtra, Uttar Pradesh and Haryana, joined in too. “We all travelled together from Pune in an overnight bus. We got in touch with each other through a WhatsApp group and decided where we would meet after reaching Delhi,” said 27-year-old Purva.

A protester from Maharashtra, who said he had travelled to Delhi solely to participate in the demonstration, described education as the foundation of the country’s development and alleged that the system would deteriorate if quality education was not ensured.

A government job aspirant from Bihar said the protesters had gathered peacefully to make their voices heard and seek answers from the authorities. He said many young people had spent years preparing for competitive examinations and deserved transparency and accountability.

In Delhi, normal life was disrupted till late in the evening. Though large parts of central Delhi were gridlocked as the protests gathered pace and security personnel swarmed the streets, the ripple effects were seen all over.

Delhi Police

The clarification came after CJP leaders accused the police of using lathi charge, tear gas and excessive force against demonstrators. Protest organisers also claimed several protesters were detained and demanded that police action against what they called a peaceful movement be stopped.

Delhi Police also denied allegations that climate activist Sonam Wangchuk’s wife, Geetanjali Angmo, was assaulted and her hair pulled by police personnel. It termed the claims “completely false and misleading”, adding, “No individuals were subjected to targeted assault, and claims suggesting malicious force or personal targeting are entirely baseless.”

The police further rejected reports that CJP founder Abhijit Dipke had been detained, saying the allegations were “entirely false” and stating that he was “available on stage” during the protest.

Centre opens

Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan, and Rs.1 crore compensation for the families of NEET aspirants who committed suicide in the aftermath of the paper leak.

According to the CJP, Nadda sought time to consult the government leadership before responding to the demands. Ranka said, “The minister requested additional time to discuss the issues with the Centre’s leadership.” While Das said the delegation had received no commitments despite a detailed discussion.

“The minister assured us that our demands would be discussed at the appropriate level, but no commitments have been made so far,” Das said, adding that the protest would continue until the demands were met.

The CJP also claimed that Nadda assured the delegation there would be no further police crackdown at Jantar Mantar and adjoining protest sites.

Following the meeting, Nadda described the discussions as “cordial” and said the initiative for talks had come

from the protesters. In a post on X, he said, “discussions had been underway since 11.50 am and that the delegation submitted its written memorandum around 4 pm after detailed verbal deliberations.”

The health minister added, “I have requested all the protesters to end their sit-in and assist the administration in restoring normalcy.”

However, the CJP rejected the appeal, maintaining that the protest would continue until its three demands are met.

The meeting marked the first official engagement between the protesting outfit and the Centre since the agitation began about a month ago, but with neither side shifting its stand, the deadlock over the NEET-UG 2026 controversy remains unresolved.

The government has asked protesters under the banner of the satirical political group CJP to end their sit-in at central Delhi’s Jantar Mantar, following a meeting between Nadda and CJP members Das and Ranka.

The CJP said they also demanded an end to police action against “peaceful protesters”.

In the memorandum submitted to Nadda, the CJP alleged repeated failures in the conduct of public examinations, including the NEET 2026 paper leak, CBSE Class XII portal issues and delays in CUET, and said its core demand since the start of the agitation had been the removal of Pradhan as education minister.

It also sought Wangchuk’s release without restrictions on his movement and urged the government to direct Delhi Police to stop using force against peaceful protesters.

Ranka said it was only late Sunday night that the Deputy Commissioner of Police, New Delhi, reached out for opening a communication channel with the government.

He said there were more serious discussions only from 6 am on Monday, and only at around 11:45 am, there was “an alignment on meeting Nadda ji”.

The CJP has been spearheading protests over alleged examination irregularities since June.

Climate activist Sonam Wangchuk, who joined the agitation on June 28 and has been on a hunger strike, remains admitted to Safdarjung Hospital after being shifted there by Delhi Police on July 18.

Protesters participating in the Cockroach Janta Party’s Parliament march on Monday refused to disperse despite heavy police barricading, lathicharge and use of tear gas and raised slogans demanding the resignation of Pradhan.

The march, which witnessed participation of students and people from across Delhi, was stopped near Parliament Street, where police had put up multiple layers of barricades.

Ram temple

examined the allegations and concluded that a cognisable offence was made out, following which the police registered an FIR and took over the investigation. The court noted that the SIT included two senior IAS officers and the Inspector General of Police, Lucknow, and asked whether the same panel could conduct the investigation to ensure fairness and transparency.

The bench directed the state government to respond on the issue and listed the matter for further hearing on July 27. It also indicated that it would consider issuing directions on preserving and uploading donation receipts after one of the petitioners sought safeguards for financial records.

The case stems from allegations of misappropriation of temple donations. According to the status placed before the court, the investigation has so far resulted in the arrest of eight accused and the recovery of nearly Rs 80 lakh allegedly siphoned from donation funds. The probe also led to the resignations of former Trust general secretary Champat Rai and former trustee Anil Mishra.

Petitions before the court, filed by Narendra Kumar Goswami, advocates Ajay Kumar Rai and Dinesh Kumar Yadav, and RJD MP Sudhakar Singh, have sought a Supreme Court-monitored CBI investigation, a forensic audit and a CAG audit of the Trust’s finances. The Uttar Pradesh government had constituted the SIT on June 13 following a request from the Trust after allegations of financial

irregularities surfaced. Meanwhile, the Trust is scheduled to meet in Ayodhya on July 22 to review the SIT’s findings and consider corrective measures.

Four Indians

Indian nationals and wish the injured Indian national a speedy and full recovery,” the MEA said in a statement.

India also condemned the attack, calling any assault on commercial shipping and civilian crew members unacceptable. “India condemns such attacks and reiterates that targeting commercial shipping and endangering innocent civilian crew members, or otherwise impeding freedom of navigation and commerce, is deplorable and should be avoided,” the statement said.

The government did not identify who was responsible for the attack. The incident comes as hostilities between Ukraine and Russia continue to intensify.

NEET

Speaker Om Birla objected to slogan shouting during obituary references for six former MPs and adjourned the Lok Sabha shortly after Question Hour began. Later, Presiding Officer Dilip Saikia appealed to opposition members to return to their seats, saying the House was ready for discussions. “You are disrupting the House repeatedly. You are showing banners and posters which is not acceptable,” he said.

In the Rajya Sabha, Deputy Chairman Hariyavansh urged members to maintain order. “The House is for dialogue and discussion. Please, let us debate,” he said before adjourning proceedings.

Amid the disruptions, Law Minister Arjun Ram Meghwal introduced a bill in the Lok Sabha to replace an ordinance increasing the strength of Supreme Court judges from 34 to 38, including the Chief Justice of India. However, a bill proposing punishment for insulting Vande Mataram could not be introduced in the Rajya Sabha.

Outside Parliament, security personnel used batons and tear gas to disperse protesters near the Constitution Club, the Reserve Bank of India and Shastri Bhavan after they broke barricades and tried to move towards Parliament. Some Parliament gates were briefly closed as the crowd swelled nearby.

During the afternoon sitting, an MP raised concerns that some lawmakers had been stopped from entering Parliament, but the Chair, Jagdambika Pal, said all MPs were being allowed.

Congress leaders also targeted the government over the police action. Priyanka Gandhi Vadra demanded a detailed debate in Parliament on the paper leak issue and said Prime Minister Narendra Modi should respond to the concerns of the country’s youth. Rahul Gandhi described Modi as the “most anti-youth” Prime Minister in the country’s history.

Ferran-tastic

voice still catching. “It wasn’t mine, or even just the team’s. It felt like something that was simply meant to happen.”

It was hard not to feel a quiet shudder of nostalgia. Sixteen years after Iniesta’s extra-time winner against the Netherlands, the script felt almost hauntingly familiar: 1-0. Extra time. A cold-blooded finish inside the box to claim a second star.

The television cameras soon found the architects of that victory. Sergio Ramos embraced David Villa. Iker Casillas smiled alongside Carlos Puyol. Iniesta applauded quietly from the stands, perhaps the only person in the stadium who fully understood what Torres was experiencing.

The final itself, though, will not be remembered as a classic. The meeting between the tournament’s two outstanding teams never truly caught fire. Spain monopolised possession but lacked incision. Argentina became increasingly consumed by the task of preventing rather than creating, making history as the first side to complete the regulation 90 minutes of a World Cup final without

attempting a single shot.

Lionel Messi, playing in his third World Cup final, found himself isolated for long periods. At the other end, Lamine Yamal, whose brilliance had illuminated so much of Spain’s campaign, was kept unusually quiet. The decisive contribution came instead from the bench, with Williams providing the invention and Torres applying the finish.

The frustration that had simmered throughout finally spilled over after the final whistle. Players confronted one another in the centre circle after an increasingly physical contest that had already seen Enzo Fernández sent off for a late challenge on Pau Cubarsí. It was a fitting end to a final that often resembled a test of endurance more than a football match.None of that will matter in years to come.

World Cup finals are rarely remembered for the quality of the football. They are remembered for the team that found the decisive moment. Spain did, and in doing so reaffirmed something that has become their greatest strength.

This squad may never be spoken of in quite the same reverential tones as the class of Xavi, Iniesta, Casillas, Puyol and David Villa, the side that redefined modern football. Yet they arrived at precisely the same destination.

Like their predecessors, they trusted the ball, the system and one another. They smothered Portugal, squeezed past Belgium, dismantled France and finally outlasted Argentina, never abandoning the philosophy that has become Spain’s footballing DNA.

At a time when many of football’s traditional powers continue searching for a clear identity, Spain never stopped believing in theirs. And for the second time, that unwavering faith carried La Roja to the summit of world football.

Tripura DGP

Dr Pradip Bhowmik, Medical Officer at GB Pant Hospital, said Dhankar was brought to the hospital at around 12 pm with no detectable vital signs. “We immediately started CPR, and our medical team continued resuscitation efforts for 48 minutes. At 12:48 pm, he was declared dead,” Bhowmik told local media. A post-mortem examination was later conducted at the hospital.

Monday had begun as a routine working day at the police headquarters, where the DGP and other senior officers were expected to attend to official duties. The sudden death of the state’s top police officer brought normal functioning to a halt.

Chief Minister Manik Saha rushed to the police headquarters after learning of the incident but declined to comment to the media. Several cabinet ministers were also present at GB Pant Hospital during the post-mortem examination. Senior minister Ratan Lal Nath told reporters, “No comments until the post-mortem report is available.”

Leader of the Opposition Jitendra Chaudhury, who is also a CPI(M) Polit Bureau member, demanded a judicial inquiry into the DGP’s death and criticised the state government’s handling of law and order. Responding to the allegations, BJP state president Rajib Bhat-tacharjee accused the CPI(M) of attempting to politicise the tragedy by making baseless allegations and spreading misinformation.

Dhankar’s body has been kept at his official residence. His wife is in Agartala, while his son is expected to arrive from Canada.

A 1994-batch IPS officer of the Tripura cadre, Dhankar was widely respected for his professionalism, integrity and dedication to public service. During his distinguished career, he served in several premier organisations, including the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI), the Bureau of Police Research and Development (BPR&D), and the Border Security Force (BSF). He was held in high regard across the Tripura Police, and his sudden death has left the force in deep mourning.

The exact circumstances surrounding Dhankar’s death remain under investigation. Authorities are expected to provide further details after the post-mortem report and the completion of the official inquiry.

DCGI clears

QDenga is a live attenuated tetravalent vaccine developed by Japan’s Takeda. It is designed to protect against all four dengue virus serotypes, DENV-1, DENV-2, DENV-3 and DENV-4. Unlike the earlier dengue vaccine Dengvaxia, QDenga can be given regardless of whether a person has previously been infected with dengue and does not require pre-vaccination blood testing, a feature that could simplify large-scale vaccination programmes.

The vaccine has been approved in India for people aged 4 to 60 years. It is administered as a 0.5 ml subcutaneous injection in a two-dose schedule, with the second dose given three months after the first.

Takeda said the approval is based on its global clinical development programme, which included 19 Phase I, II and III clinical trials involving more than 28,000 participants from both dengue-endemic and non-endemic regions. The authorisation is also supported by findings from the Phase III DEN-302 trial conducted in India, which evaluated the vaccine’s safety and immune response in participants aged 4 to 60 years.

The company also cited long-term findings from the pivotal TIDES Phase III trial, which enrolled more than 20,000 children and adolescents across eight dengue-endemic countries. After 4.5 years of follow-up, the vaccine demonstrated 84 per cent protection against dengue-related hospitalisation and around 61 per cent protection against virologically confirmed dengue. Takeda said the latest seven-year data continue to show protection against dengue infection and hospitalisation across all four virus serotypes.

“Since its launch in 2022, QDenga has been approved in 43 countries, with more than 32 million doses distributed globally. This approval marks an important step forward in strengthening dengue prevention in India,” said Mahender Nayak, Head of Inter-continental Markets at Takeda.

QDenga has already received approvals in more than 40 countries, including the European Union, the United Kingdom, Brazil, Indonesia and Argentina. It has also received World Health Organization prequalification, confirming that it meets international standards for quality, safety and efficacy. The certification allows procurement through agencies such as UNICEF and the Pan American Health Organization to support wider access.

The WHO recommends the vaccine for use in dengue-endemic settings and supports its introduction in public immunisation programmes in areas with high transmission without requiring pre-vaccination screening.

Goh Choo Beng, Medical Affairs Head, Southeast Asia and India Cluster at Takeda, said India faces a significant dengue burden, with all four virus serotypes circulating in several parts of the country.

“QDenga is designed to protect against all four serotypes, regardless of prior exposure. Its approval represents an important step in strengthening India’s comprehensive approach to dengue prevention, alongside vector control, surveillance, community awareness and other public health measures,” Beng said.

India has witnessed a sharp rise in dengue cases over the past two decades, driven by rapid urbanisation, population growth, climate change and changing mosquito habitats. Seasonal outbreaks continue to strain healthcare facilities, particularly during the monsoon and post-monsoon months.

While the approval introduces a new preventive option, health authorities and experts maintain that vaccination alone cannot eliminate dengue. They say mosquito control, removal of breeding sites, personal protection against mosquito bites, disease surveillance, timely diagnosis and access to healthcare will remain central to reducing transmission, especially as all four dengue virus serotypes continue to circulate.

Takeda has partnered with Hyderabad-based Biological E to manufacture up to 50 million doses annually in India, a move expected to improve supply and potentially lower costs over time. However, the company has not yet announced the vaccine’s price or timeline for commercial availability, and it remains unclear whether it will initially be offered through the private market or later be included in government immunisation programmes. MP05T



CALLS FOR PRODUCTIVE MONSOON SESSION

PM: Every voice should find an opportunity to be heard in Parl

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Monday called for a productive Monsoon Session of Parliament, saying there would be no room for chaos or raising voice if discussions in the House are conducted with logic and facts.

His remarks came ahead of the start of the Monsoon Session of Parliament, which will be stormy with the Opposition set to raise the issues of the NEET paper leak, the alleged theft of donations at the Ram temple in Ayodhya and E20 petrol.

Addressing reporters in Parliament complex, the Prime Minister said the seasonal monsoon is beginning to show its positive impact, and the Monsoon Session of Parliament is also commencing.

"When both are productive, they contribute to the well-being of the nation and of all living beings. With this hope, we pray that the monsoon remains proactive and that the Monsoon Session is equally productive," he said.

He said as the session begins, the country has picked up speed, and Parliament's



Prime Minister Narendra Modi addresses the media on the first day of the Monsoon session of Parliament, in New Delhi, Monday

spirit can infuse new energy into this momentum and a positive spirit is essential to achieve national goals.

Modi stressed that meaningful discussions should take place in the House and collective resolutions made to move the country forward.

"Our House has many experienced Parliamentarians, regardless of party, whose knowledge and wisdom are needed by Parliament and the nation. Therefore, Parliament must function, meaningful discussions must take place, and collective resolutions must be made to move the country forward.

ward. This is the demand of the times and the aspiration of the youth," he said.

The prime minister said today, the demand is that voices filled with patriotism and national devotion find a proper platform in Parliament, to raise the voices of the youth and guide the nation.

"I believe where there are facts, there is no need for chaos. If your logic and facts are strong, there is no need to raise your voice. Strong arguments and strong facts allow voices to be raised calmly yet powerfully. Every voice should find an opportunity to be heard. That is

Highlights

» 'Our House has many experienced Parliamentarians, regardless of party, whose knowledge and wisdom are needed by Parliament and the nation'

» Modi stressed that meaningful discussions should take place and collective resolutions made to move the country forward

the role of Parliament. I urge all parliamentarians to participate in the proceedings wholeheartedly," he said.

Modi also took a veiled dig at Congress leader Rahul Gandhi while hailing young innovators behind India's first privately developed orbital rocket, saying he was not talking about a "56-year-old young man".

He said there have been moments of glory just before the Monsoon Session last year as an Indian citizen reached the International Space Station and only the day before yesterday, a young Indian start-up accomplished an extraordinary feat.

Modi 'most anti-youth' PM in India's history, attacks Rahul

Gandhi slams lathi charge against CJP protesters

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Congress leader Rahul Gandhi on Monday dubbed Prime Minister Narendra Modi as the "most anti-youth" PM in the country's history as he accused the government of not just failing the youth but also pouncing on them.

Gandhi's remarks came after security forces resorted to a baton charge near Parliament Street after thousands of Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) supporters, protesting against the paper leaks, allegedly tried to breach barricades while marching towards Parliament on the first day of the Monsoon session.

As CJP supporters, including students, marched towards Parliament, the police tried to stop them and used teargas and lathi-charged them.

"Prime Minister Modi is the 'most anti-youth Prime Minister in India's history — He's so 'anti-youth' that he can't even take the resignation of a failed Education Minister, Dharmendra Pradhan.

"152 paper leaks. 7.5 crore students victimised. And not a single guilty person punished. Who got the punishment? The

Closer Look

» 'This govt is not just failing the youth — it is pouncing on them'

» Gandhi said peaceful protest is an "inviolable and fundamental right"

» Gandhi said when children raise legitimate questions about education, they are met with batons and detention in response

hardworking youth," he said in a post in Hindi on X.

He also attached a video message with his post in which he criticised the government and the police for action against the protesting students, whom he supported while terming their demands as "legitimate". The video also showed pictures of protesting students being beaten up by the cops.

Gandhi said when children raise legitimate questions about education, they are met with batons and detention in response.

"The criminals who leaked the papers room free — and the students raising valid issues are dragged around, beaten.

"This government is not just failing the youth — it is pouncing on them," the leader of Opposition in Lok Sabha said.

In another post on X, Gandhi said peaceful protest is an "inviolable and fundamental right".

"Every police officer and government employee blindly following orders to attack India's innocent students should keep this in mind:

"The Constitution is your master. Power does not last forever. Accountability will certainly be enforced," the Congress leader said in his post.

In his video message, Gandhi said this country has a majority of young people and "Prime Minister Narendra Modi is the most anti-youth prime minister India has ever had." He said the boys and girls who are walking the streets of Delhi are not criminals and they are demanding their rights.

"Their rights are to have an education system that respects them, to have an education system that is fair, to have an education system that is working. There's absolutely nothing wrong in what they are doing. And it is disgusting what the government is doing and what the police is doing.

NSA Doval to receive Lokmanya Tilak Award on August 1

PUNE: National Security Advisor Ajit Doval has been selected for the prestigious Lokmanya Tilak Award for his significant contribution to the field of national security, the Tilak Smarak Trust announced on Monday.

Union Home minister Amit Shah will present the award to Doval at a function in Pune on August 1. Maharashtra Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis, Deputy CMs Eknath Shinde and Sunetra Pawar are likely to attend the event, the trust's president, Rohit Tilak, said at a press conference.

The award ceremony will be held at the Maharashtra Mandal ground in the Gultekdi area of Pune. Doval, 81, has handled crucial assignments in sensitive regions, including Mizoram, Sikkim, Punjab and Jammu and Kashmir. He also served in diplomatic roles at Indian missions in Islamabad and London.

He is the longest-serving National Security Advisor of India. Doval has served as India's special representative for the India-China boundary talks and is also credited with playing an important role in diplomatic efforts that helped resolve the Doklam standoff.

Instituted in 1983, the Lokmanya Tilak Award was first conferred on socialist leader S M Joshi. It is awarded every year on August 1, the death anniversary of freedom fighter Bal Gangadhar Tilak, to individuals who have made a remarkable contribution to the nation's progress and development.

Over the years, the award has been presented to several eminent personalities, including Prime Minister Narendra Modi, former PMs Atal Bihari Vajpayee and Manmohan Singh. Congress leader Sonia Gandhi, former President Pranab Mukherjee and veteran politician Sharad Pawar. MPOST

AHEAD OF PARL SESSION

Usual litany of platitudes: Congress slams PM's remarks

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Congress on Monday said Prime Minister Narendra Modi started off Parliament's Monsoon session with his "usual litany of platitudes" and that he failed to mention key issues such as Ram temple donation "theft", NEET UG paper leak and "dirty tricks" being used to split Opposition parties.

Congress general secretary in-charge communications Jairam Ramesh also said the PM failed to talk about his government's ongoing attempts to subvert democracy and the federal setup of the Constitution through a "compromised delimitation process, the One Nation One Election gimmick, and the unconstitutional VBSA Bill".

Addressing reporters ahead of the Parliament session, Prime Minister Narendra Modi said there would be no room for chaos or raising voice if discussions in the House were conducted with logic and facts.

He also spoke about the impact of the West Asia conflict on India and its growing space sector. The prime minister said that whether it is the seasonal monsoon or the monsoon session, if both are proactive, then they become highly

'Parliament cannot be notice board': Tharoor slams govt

NEW DELHI: Congress leader Shashi Tharoor on Monday hit out at the government for not allowing a discussion in Parliament on issues such as the alleged theft of donations at the Ram temple in Ayodhya and the NEET-UG paper leak, saying Parliament cannot be a notice board for announcing Bills and getting them passed.

Tharoor referred to the old adage that the Opposition must have its say because the government will have its way, to stress that Parliament is supposed to be the place where MPs can ventilate the voice of the people. MPOST

productive and if both are productive, then it ensures the welfare of the country.

Reacting to the PM's remarks, Ramesh said Modi started off the Monsoon session with his "usual litany of platitudes".

Raj: HC orders holding of Panchayat, local bodies polls in mid-August

JAIPUR: A division bench of the Rajasthan High Court on Monday paved the way for holding Panchayat and local bodies elections in the state.

The bench comprising Acting Chief Justice Sanjeev Prakash Sharma and Justice Sanjeev Purohit disapproved the state's proposal to hold the elections after the OBC Political Reservation Commission's report.

The bench directed the election to be declared and held for local bodies in mid-August irrespective of the commission making its recommendations or not. According to the government's affidavit, it was requested that the election process should commence in August.

The state govt suggested that once the OBC Commission submit its report, it shall be followed by the reservation draw (lottery), after which the State Election Commission will conduct the elections within 90 days, firstly for the urban bodies and thereafter for the Panchayats. AGENCIES

Newly-elected members take oath in Rajya Sabha

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Rajya Sabha Chairman C P Radhakrishnan on Monday administered the oath to nine newly-elected members of the Upper House, including three who recently switched sides from the Trinamool Congress.

The members who took the oath represent the states of Gujarat, Karnataka, Madhya Pradesh, Meghalaya, Mizoram, Rajasthan and West Bengal.

The newly-elected members who took the oath on the first day of the Monsoon session included BJP member Satish Poonia from Rajasthan, Congress member Pawan Kherra from Karnataka and three BJP members from West Bengal - Prakash Chik Baraik, Sushmita Dev and Sukhendu Sekhar Ray.

Others who also took the oath included Mukeshbhai J Rathwa (BJP-Gujarat), Mahesh Kewat (BJP, Madhya Pradesh), Jamesh Pangsang Kongkal Sangma (NPP-Meghalaya) and Kiangte Lalitugakima (Mizoram).

As soon as Mahesh Kewat took the oath, some Congress members started shouting "seat chori" in the house.

The newly-elected members later met the chairman of the Rajya Sabha, who congratulated all the new members.

Five members took the oath in Hindi, two in English and two in Bengali.

Some other members elected earlier had already taken their oath during the inter-session period.

LS: Bill to increase number of SC judges introduced amid din

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: A Bill to replace an ordinance which increased the number of Supreme Court judges by four was introduced in the Lok Sabha on Monday, with the government asserting that an enhanced strength is one of the most exigent and viable solutions for tackling pendency in the top court.

Law minister Arjun Ram Meghwal introduced the Bill amid slogan-shouting by Opposition members over NEET paper leak and alleged Ram temple donation theft.

In May, the Union Cabinet had cleared the Bill to increase the sanctioned strength of the top court, but soon thereafter the government brought an ordinance.

After the ordinance, five judges were appointed to the apex court based on the upgraded sanctioned strength.

The Bill does not require an amendment to the Constitution and requires a simple majority for passage.

After the ordinance was issued, the sanctioned strength of the apex court went up to 38 from 34, including the Chief



Union minister Arjun Ram Meghwal speaks in the Lok Sabha during the Monsoon session of Parliament, in New Delhi

Justice of India.

According to the Bill, the volume of litigation of cases in the Supreme Court has con-

India records 78 doping cases till July 15, UP, Punjab top list: Mandaviya in LS

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: India has recorded 78 doping cases till July 15 this year with Uttar Pradesh and Punjab accounting for the biggest share of 13 violations each so far, Sports minister Mansukh Mandaviya revealed on Monday in response to a query in Lok Sabha.

After BJP MP Sambit Patra posed a query on the number of athletes who have tested positive for banned substances during the last three years, Mandaviya, in a written response, said 78 Adverse Analytical Findings (AAFs) have been recorded so far in 2026.

"These athletes have been banned from the Sports activ-



Union minister Mansukh Mandaviya speaks in the Lok Sabha during the Monsoon session of Parliament, in New Delhi

ities in accordance with the National Anti-Doping Rules, 2021. The sanctions, as determined by the Anti-Doping Disciplinary Panel (ADDP) include disqualification of results, forfeiture of medals/prizes, period of ineligibility from participation in sports,

and other consequences as prescribed under the WADA Code 2021," the Minister stated.

In a state-wise list of AAFs, it was revealed that after Uttar Pradesh and Punjab, Madhya Pradesh threw up the highest number of dope offenders -- 11 -- this year, followed by Karnataka, which had nine cases.

In 2023, India reported 213 doping violations, which increased to 260 in 2024 before the number decreased sharply to 131 in 2025.

No dope violations have been found so far this year among athletes representing Arunachal Pradesh, Assam, Bihar, Goa, Himachal Pradesh, Nagaland, Manipur, Meghalaya and Sikkim.

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The government said on Monday that the states and Union territories received 18,790 complaints of financial irregularities and poor work quality under the Jal Jeevan Mission, a rural drinking water scheme, leading to action against 635 departmental officials, 1,020 contractors and 155 third-party inspection agencies.

In a written reply to a question from

Congress MP Mukul Wasnik in the Rajya Sabha, Minister of State for Jal Shakti V Somanna said the complaints were received from various sources, including media reports, suo motu cognisance, references from public representatives, citizens and grievance portals.

Somanna said drinking water is a state subject and, therefore, under the Jal Jeevan Mission (JJM), the responsibility for planning, approval, implementation, operation

and maintenance of drinking water supply schemes lies with the state and Union territory governments.

At the same time, the Government of India provides technical and financial assistance.

The minister said the departmental officials involved in irregularities are facing administrative action, including suspension, departmental inquiries and issuance of charge sheets as per established procedures.

He said actions taken for contractors include blacklisting or recommendations for blacklisting, termination of contracts, debarment, forfeiture of earnest money deposits, and imposition of penalties, depending on the nature of the violation.

Somanna said concerning third-party inspection agencies, the relevant persons have been removed from empanelment, and in other cases, show-cause notices have been issued and recoveries initiated.

ग्रेटर नौएडा औद्योगिक विकास प्राधिकरण

प्लॉट नं.-1, सेक्टर के.पी.-4, ग्रेटर नौएडा सिटी, गौतमबुद्ध नगर-201308, उ.प्र.
वेबसाइट: www.greaternoidaauthority.in ई-मेल: authority@gnida.in

पत्रांक: वरि.प्र./ (ई-निविदा सेल)/ 2026 / 785 दिनांक: 20.07.2026

ई-निविदा आमंत्रण सूचना

वरिष्ठ प्रबंधक (वर्क सर्फिल-7) ग्रेटर नौएडा औद्योगिक विकास प्राधिकरण द्वारा मुख्य कार्यपालक अधिकारी, ग्रेटर नौएडा की ओर से ई-निविदा आमंत्रण सूचना संख्या-वरि.प्र. निविदा सेल/2026/784 दिनांक-20.07.2026 के माध्यम से उल्लेखित क्रम संख्या-02 पर अंकित कार्यों की ई-निविदा आमंत्रित की जाती है। ई-निविदा की समस्त नियम व शर्तें ग्रेटर नौएडा प्राधिकरण की वेबसाइट: www.greaternoidaauthority.in पर ई-निविदा लिंक एवं ई-पोर्टल https://etender.up.nic.in पर उपलब्ध है। किसी परिवर्तन, संशोधन व अतिरिक्त सूचनाओं के लिए उक्त वेबसाइट देखें रहें।

क्र.सं.	कार्य का नाम/वर्क सर्फिल	अनुमानित लागत
1.	Supply of 01 CNG Based Truck Mounted Mechanical Road Sweeping Machine and Comprehensive Operation and Maintenance for a Period of 01 year.	रु. 1.70 करोड़
2.	Supply of 04 CNG Based Truck Mounted Anti - Smog Guns-	रु. 2.40 करोड़

क्रम सं. 01 से 02 तक जिन्हें दिनांक 22.07.2026 से 31.07.2026 को 17:00 बजे तक अपलोड किया जा सकता है, एवं प्राप्त ई-निविदाओं की प्री-क्वालिफिकेशन दिनांक 03.08.2026 को 11:00 बजे खोली जायेगी।

वरिष्ठ प्रबंधक (वर्क सर्फिल-7)

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कार्यालय, जिला परिषद्, चतरा

(Mail Id- db-chatra@jharkhandmail.gov.in) (E.mail: districtboardchatra@gmail.com)

(अतिअल्पकालिक ई0निविदा आमंत्रण सूचना)

ई-निविदा सूचना संख्या - 32/2026-27 दिनांक:

1. कार्य की विस्तृत विवरणी: जी.एम.एफ.टी.

SI No.	Name of work	Estimate Cost	Cost of Boq	Earnest Money	time of completion
1	Construction of 10 ACR at project Girl's High School, Itkhor, Block-Itkhor.	32026200	10000	641000	18 months

1. वेबसाइट में निविदा प्रकाशन की तिथि - 29 / 07 / 2026

2. ई-निविदा प्राप्ति की तिथि एवं समय - 01.08.2026 से 07.08.2026 के अपराह्न 5:00 बजे तक

3. निविदा खोलने की तिथि एवं समय - 10.08.2026 पूर्वाह्न 11:00 बजे।

4. सरकार द्वारा लिए गए निर्णय के आलोक में सभी कागजात के साथ निविदा शुल्क एवं अग्रधन की राशि online Mode द्वारा स्वीकार्य होगा।

5. निविदा शुल्क एवं अग्रधन की राशि का ई-मुगतान जिस खाता से किया जायेगा, उसी खाते में अग्रधन की राशि वापस होगी। अगर खाता को बंद कर दिया जाता है तो उसकी सारी जवाबदेही संबंधित निविदाकार की होगी।

6. निविदा आमंत्रित करने वाले पदाधिकारी का नाम एवं पता - जिला अभियंता जिला परिषद चतरा।

7. ई-निविदा प्रकोष्ठ का दूरभाष सं० - 9835777636

10. विस्तृत जानकारी के लिए वेबसाइट www.jharkhandtenders.gov.in एवं कार्यालय की सूचना पट्ट पर देखा जा सकता है।

जिला अभियंता, जिला परिषद, चतरा।

PR.NO.385353 District(26-27):D

MORE DOWNPOURS EXPECTED

Heavy rains batter north India; J&K toll reaches 23

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: Heavy monsoon rains continued to batter large parts of north and northeast India on Monday, claiming more lives, triggering landslides and flash floods, blocking highways and disrupting normal life across several states. Jammu and Kashmir remained the worst-hit, where the death toll in rain-related incidents climbed to 23 over the past two days, while Uttarakhand, Himachal Pradesh, Uttar Pradesh, Delhi, Punjab, Haryana and Assam also witnessed widespread disruption amid forecasts of more intense rainfall.

The India Meteorological Department (IMD) warned that the monsoon is likely to remain active over northwest and northeast India for the next four to five days. It forecast very heavy rainfall at isolated places in Jammu and Kashmir, Himachal Pradesh and Uttar Pradesh on July 20 and 21, while Uttara-



People wade through a knee-deep waterlogged road after heavy rain, in Srinagar, Monday

PTI

HIGHLIGHTS

» Uttarakhand, Himachal Pradesh, Uttar Pradesh, Delhi, Punjab, Haryana and Assam also witnessed widespread disruption amid forecasts of more intense rainfall

» The India Meteorological Department (IMD) warned that the monsoon is likely to remain active over northwest and northeast India for the next four to five days

khand, Bihar, Assam and Meghalaya are expected to receive heavy rainfall. According to the weather office, the prevailing conditions have been caused by the weakening of a low-pressure system over the Bay of Bengal and the strengthening of the monsoon current over north India.

Jammu and Kashmir bore the brunt of the extreme weather as at least 11 more people, includ-

ing a mother and her two children, lost their lives on Monday, taking the overall toll to 23. Seven people remained missing in the flood-hit districts of Poonch and Rajouri as rescue teams battled swollen streams, slippery terrain and poor visibility.

In one of the worst tragedies, seven members of a family, including a woman and her two children, were buried alive

after a rain-triggered landslide collapsed their mud house in the upper reaches of Loran in Poonch district. Rescue operations, hampered by continuous rainfall through the morning, intensified after weather conditions improved, but the missing persons could not be traced till late evening.

Heavy rains also disrupted connectivity in the Union Ter-

ritory. The Jammu-Kishtwar National Highway remained blocked after boulders rolled onto the road and struck private vehicles. Although the vehicles were damaged, their occupants escaped without injuries.

In neighbouring Uttarakhand, incessant rainfall triggered landslides at multiple locations, forcing the closure of nearly 150 roads, including four national highways. As a precautionary measure, authorities suspended the Char Dham Yatra on Monday. An eight-year-old child was swept away in the swollen Saryu River in Bageshwar district.

The IMD issued a Red Alert for Dehradun, Tehri and Haridwar districts, warning of heavy to very heavy rainfall, while the remaining districts remained under an Orange Alert. Authorities placed the administration on round-the-clock vigil and declared a holiday for schools from Classes I to XII across the state to ensure students' safety.

Himachal Pradesh also faced widespread disruption. The weather department issued a Red Alert for Chamba, Kangra, Mandi and Sirmour districts on Monday, extending it to Chamba, Kangra, Kullu, Mandi and Sirmour for Tuesday. Educational institutions in Kangra, Mandi and Sirmour will remain closed on July 21.

According to the State Emergency Operation Centre, 36 roads, including 11 in Mandi and 10 in Chamba, remained closed due to landslides and debris. Additionally, 43 water supply schemes and five electricity transformers were affected by the persistent rainfall.

In Uttar Pradesh, the IMD issued a Red Alert, warning of extremely heavy rainfall in several districts over the next 24 hours. A Yellow Alert has also been issued for parts of southern Uttar Pradesh from July 21 to July 25 as monsoon activity intensifies across the state.

At least five dead as flood situation worsens in Assam

Nearly 3.63 lakh people affected



Floodwaters inundate the area around a railway bridge in Sivasagar

PTI

MPOST BUREAU

GUWAHATI: The flood situation in Assam worsened on Monday, with nearly 3.63 lakh people affected across 15 districts and five more persons losing their lives, as the Army joined state agencies in rescue operations amid incessant rain.

The Assam State Disaster Management Authority (ASDMA) said two men and two girls drowned in floodwaters in Jorhat district, while another person died in Karbi Anglong district.

Besides, one person each was reported missing in Charaideo and Karbi Anglong districts.

With these fatalities, the total number of deaths in this year's floods has increased to 10, the ASDMA said.

More than 3,62,900 people have been affected in Biswanath, Cachar, Charaideo, Chirang, Dhemaji, Dibrugarh, Golaghat, Jorhat, Kamrup, Kamrup Metropolitan, Karbi Anglong, Nagaon, Sivasagar, Tinsukia and Udalguri districts, it said.

Sivasagar is the worst-hit district, with nearly 1.58 lakh people affected, followed by Charaideo with around 1.05 lakh and Jorhat with about 51,000 people reeling under floodwaters, it added.

With the situation worsening, Army personnel have been deployed in Upper Assam to assist the National Disaster Response Force (NDRF), SDRF, Fire and

Emergency Services and district authorities in rescue and relief operations, officials said.

According to the ASDMA, nearly 7,000 people have been rescued from Charaideo, Golaghat, Jorhat, Karbi Anglong and Nagaon.

Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma said four cabinet ministers have been stationed in the affected districts to supervise relief measures, while MPs and MLAs from the flood-hit areas have also been asked to remain on the ground.

According to the Chief Minister's Office (CMO), 510 people have so far been rescued in Sivasagar by the SDRF and Fire and Emergency Services, with Army helicopters and additional boats deployed to reach marooned residents in inaccessible areas.

In neighbouring Charaideo, teams of the Army, NDRF and SDRF have been deployed in the worst-affected locations to carry out rescue operations and distribute relief.

The floods have also severely disrupted rail services in the region.

Northeast Frontier Railway (NFR) Chief Public Relations Officer Kapinjal Kishore Sharma said train movement in the Simaluguri-Namtiali and Simaluguri-Selenghat sections has been suspended after floodwaters from the overflowing Dikhow river inundated the Simaluguri station yard, railway colony and tracks.

Haryana government advances 21 priority deregulation reforms

CHANDIGARH: Haryana has emerged as one of the leading states in the Centre's compliance reduction and deregulation initiative, with 21 of the 28 priority reforms either approved or under implementation to create a simpler, faster and more business-friendly regulatory environment, according to an official statement issued on Monday.

Reviewing the progress of Phase-II of the compliance reduction and deregulation exercise, Haryana Chief Secretary Anurag Rastogi directed all departments to expedite the remaining reforms and ensure timely uploading of documentary evidence on the Management Information System (MIS) portal so that the state's progress is accurately reflected at the national level.

Rastogi said the Centre's

The move aims to create a more business-friendly regulatory environment

Deregulation Cell has already approved six major reform areas. These include faster power connections, liberalised regulations for shops and commercial establishments, improved turnaround time under the single-window system, an auto-appeal mechanism under the Right to Services framework, enhanced environmental clearance processes and better access to testing facilities for micro, small and medium enterprises (MSMEs).

Commissioner and Secretary, Industries and Com-

merce, Amit Kumar Agrawal said another 15 reforms are currently being implemented. These cover liberalised land-use norms, flexible industrial plot management, simplified building approvals, adoption of global fire safety standards, streamlined healthcare licensing, digitisation of state laws and measures to strengthen Haryana's investment ecosystem.

He said the Haryana State Industrial and Infrastructure Development Corporation (HSIIDC) has introduced industry-friendly measures such as subdivision and amalgamation of industrial plots, simplified changes in industrial projects without prior approval, leasehold-to-freehold conversion after 10 years, flexible leasing norms and liberalised development regulations.

MPOST

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs (MoHUA), in collaboration with the National Institute of Urban Affairs (NIUA), on Monday held a national-level interaction with 75 cities to review their experiences in implementing Shallow Aquifer Management (SAM) under the AMRUT mission as part of the 'Catch the Rain' campaign.

The interaction served as a platform for urban local bodies to share best practices and discuss groundwater recharge initiatives aimed at strengthening water security and enhancing climate resilience.

The meeting was chaired by Additional Secretary D. Thara and moderated by Joint Secretary Isha Kalia. Representatives



from all 75 cities participated, presenting their experiences and exchanging ideas on sustainable groundwater management.

Officials highlighted the progress made under the SAM component, with cities showcasing various groundwater rejuvenation and recharge structures that have contributed to groundwater conservation.

Among the success stories, Korba announced plans to rejuvenate 95 additional old borewells following the success of its recharge initiatives. Vizianaga-

ram reported an improvement in groundwater levels, while Nagpur said it would construct 100 more groundwater recharge structures during the current monsoon. Bhubaneswar highlighted how recharge structures have helped mitigate urban flooding by improving groundwater levels.

Groundwater experts participating in the interaction stressed that long-term sustainability of groundwater resources would depend on active community ownership and greater public participation in conservation efforts.

According to MoHUA, the interaction marked another step towards promoting scientific soil and water conservation, nature-based solutions and community-led water management practices under the AMRUT mission.

CISF to host Police Judo Championship in Hyderabad



NEW DELHI/HYDERABAD: The Central Industrial Security Force (CISF) will host the 11th All India Police Judo Cluster Championship 2026 at the GMC Balayogi Indoor Stadium in Hyderabad from July 23 to 30, bringing together more than 1,600 athletes representing 36 State Police and Central Armed Police Force (CAPF) organisations.

Organised under the aegis of the All India Police Sports Control Board (AIPSCB), the eight-day championship will feature competitions in Judo, Wushu, Taekwondo, Karate and Pencak Silat.

The curtain-raiser and media interaction were held at the National Industrial Security Academy (NISA), Hyderabad. Addressing the event, CISF Director and IG, NISA, Harpreet Kaur Sohi said the championship reflects the force's commitment to promoting sporting excellence and providing police personnel with a platform to sharpen their skills and showcase their talent at the national level.

She said the tournament would also help athletes prepare for major international events, including the 2026 Asian Games, where all five disciplines are medal events.

Olympian Parupalli Kashyap and renowned rowing coach Ismail Beg highlighted the role of sports in fostering discipline, teamwork and excellence, while encouraging participants to strive for national and international success. The previous edition of the championship was hosted by the Jammu and Kashmir Police in Srinagar.

Established in 1965, the AIPSCB comprises 53 police and central police organisations and conducts competitions in 28 sporting disciplines, with around 12,000 athletes participating annually. Its athletes delivered an impressive performance at the World Police and Fire Games 2025 in Birmingham, winning 600 medals.

MPOST

Illegal sand mining case: ED raids 16 locations in Punjab

NARESH BISWANI

NEW DELHI: The Enforcement Directorate (ED) has intensified its crackdown on an alleged illegal sand mining network in Punjab, conducting searches at 16 locations across Pathankot and Gurdaspur districts over the past fortnight and recovering Rs 1.75 crore in cash while freezing bank deposits worth over Rs 91.34 lakh.

The latest searches were carried out on July 16 by the ED's Jalandhar Zonal Office under the Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA). The investigation centres on the alleged illegal transfer of village common land (Shamlat) in Pathankot, which the agency believes was used to facilitate unlawful sand mining operations.

The money laundering case stems from an FIR registered by the Vigilance Bureau, Amritsar, against former Additional Deputy Commissioner (ADC) Kuldeep Singh and eight others. Kuldeep Singh, who was serving as ADC (Rural Development), Pathankot, before retiring, allegedly approved the transfer of the village Bhattian Shamlat land a day after his retirement.

According to the ED, the accused were involved in the illegal mining, transportation, purchase and sale of sand and riverbed material, causing substantial losses to the state exchequer through evasion of taxes and royalties. The agency has also alleged that certain government officials facilitated the illegal mining by failing to take action against contractors, quarry owners and other

entities involved.

During the searches, investigators seized several incriminating documents and found evidence suggesting that large-scale illegal mining was being carried out during the night using trucks, tipplers and excavators, many operating without registration plates.

The ED noted that a Public Interest Litigation (PIL) concerning illegal mining in the border districts of Pathankot and Gurdaspur is pending before the Punjab and Haryana High Court. The court has previously observed that unchecked mining along the International Border poses serious national security concerns, as it could aid terrorist infiltration and the smuggling of arms, drugs and other contraband.

TAX REGIME ROW

Alld HC judge challenges denial of exemption under new tax regime

MPOST BUREAU

PRAYAGRAJ: Justice Sandeep Jain, a sitting judge of the Allahabad High Court, has approached the High Court challenging the denial of exemption of statutory allowances from his total income under the new tax regime.

Hearing the writ petition, a two-judge bench comprising Justice Saumitra Dayal Singh and Justice Swarupama Chaturvedi asked the state government to apprise the court of the petition and fixed July 28 as the next date of hearing in the case.

Justice Jain, in his petition filed before the court, has challenged the denial of exemption of statutory allowances prescribed under Section 22D of the High Court Judges (Salaries and Conditions of Service) Act, 1954, from his total income after opting for the new tax regime.

Section 22D of the High Court Judges (Salaries and Conditions of Service) Act, 1954, exempts from income tax

THE ROW

» Sitting judge, Justice Sandeep Jain, has challenged the denial of exemption of statutory allowances prescribed under Section 22D of the High Court Judges (Salaries and Conditions of Service) Act, 1954, from his total income after opting for the new tax regime

» According to the petition, when Justice Jain attempted to file his ITR-2 for FY-26 under the new tax regime, the income tax portal allegedly did not permit him to claim exemption of Rs 9.85 lakh towards statutory judicial allowances, indicating that the benefit was available only under the old tax regime

the value of a high court judge's official residence, conveyance facilities, sumptuary allowance and leave travel concession.

According to the petition, when Justice Jain attempted to file his Income Tax Return (ITR-2) for the financial year 2025-26 under the new tax regime, the income tax portal allegedly did not permit him to claim exemption of Rs 9.85

lakh towards statutory judicial allowances, indicating that the benefit was available only under the old tax regime.

Justice Jain thereafter made representations to the Central Board of Direct Taxes (CBDT) and Union Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman.

In response, he only received a communication referring to the CBDT Office



» Justice Jain thereafter made representations to the Central Board of Direct Taxes (CBDT) and Union Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman

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Memorandum dated September 12, 2025.

The memorandum states that taxpayers opting for the new tax regime cannot claim such exemptions because the regime already provides liberal tax slabs, lower tax rates and higher rebates. Granting the exemption in addition would amount to extending a double benefit, it states.

ASHWANI SHARMA

SHIMLA: In a series of decisions aimed at strengthening healthcare, education and rural administration, the Himachal Pradesh Cabinet on Monday approved the grant of Non-Practising Allowance (NPA) to super-specialist faculty members possessing recognised DM, M.Ch. and DrNB qualifications serving under the Department of Medical Education and Research. The meeting was chaired by Chief Minister Sukhvinder Singh Sukhu.

The move is expected to help address the acute shortage of super-specialty doctors in the state's medical colleges and postgraduate institutions by improving the retention of senior specialists.

The Cabinet also approved a substantial increase in stipends

INSIGHT

» The move is expected to help address the acute shortage of super-specialty doctors in the state's medical colleges and postgraduate

institutions by improving the retention of senior specialists

» The Cabinet also approved a substantial increase in stipends for postgraduate medical students

for postgraduate medical students. Under the revised structure, first-year students will receive Rs 50,000 per month instead of Rs 40,000, second-year students Rs 60,000 instead of Rs 45,000, and third-year students Rs 65,000 instead of Rs 50,000.

To further strengthen medical education, the Cabinet approved the introduction of B.Sc. Medical Technology (Radiotherapy Technologist) and Bachelor of Radiation Therapy Technology courses

with 30 seats each at Indira Gandhi Medical College (IGMC), Shimla, and Dr Rajendra Prasad Government Medical College, Tanda.

Amendments to the Postgraduate/Super-Specialty Policy were also cleared. Under the revised policy, General Duty Officers and direct candidates serving as Senior Residents at Atal Institute of Medical Super Specialties (AIMSS), Chamiyana, or in Radiodiagnosis at state medical colleges in Tanda, Hamirpur, Mandi, Chamba and

Saini hails Babu Lal Badshah's message of harmony

JALANDHAR: Haryana Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini on Monday said that the life of Almast Babu Lal Badshah conveys the message of love, brotherhood, humanity and social harmony.

He said the saint, Babu Lal Badshah, believed that where there is true love, there is no place for discrimination.

Saini was addressing a gathering while attending the 43rd annual three-day fair at Sufi saint Almast Babu Lal Badshah's Darbar in Nakodar here.

In his address, Saini said that it was a matter of immense privilege and pride for him to visit the sacred land of Nakodar, associated with saint Almast Babu Lal Badshah.

He described it as a blessing to have the opportunity to pay his respects at this holy shrine.

Saini said that although Punjab and Haryana are two separate states, they share a common cultural heritage and deep social bonds.

MPOST

Prohibitory orders imposed in Mumbai from Jul 23 to Aug 6

MUMBAI: Mumbai police on Monday imposed prohibitory orders barring assembly of five or more persons in public places from July 23 to August 6, with officials stating that the move is due to apprehensions of breach of peace and disturbance to public tranquillity.

The order, issued by Deputy Commissioner of Police (Operations) Akbar Pathan under Maharashtra Police Act, also prohibits processions, use of loudspeakers and amplifying instruments, musical bands and bursting of crackers in processions etc, they added.

The order said inputs received from various sources indicated a likelihood of disturbance to public order, danger to human lives and loss of property, necessitating preventive measures.

"The restrictions will remain in force from 12.01 am on July 23 until midnight on August 6 across the areas under the jurisdiction of the Commissioner of Police of Mumbai," the order said.

It, however, exempts mar-



REPRESENTATIVE PIC

The move is due to apprehensions of breach of peace and disturbance to public tranquillity

riage ceremonies and related functions, funeral gatherings and processions, statutory meetings of companies, clubs and cooperative societies, social gatherings of clubs and associations for routine business, assemblies at cinema halls, theatres and other places of public entertainment.

The order will not cover gatherings at courts, government offices and local bodies for official work, academic activities in schools, colleges and educational institutions, and assemblies at factories, shops and establishments for normal trade and business.

MPOST



EDITORIAL
ACCOUNTABILITY
NEEDED

A democracy reveals its character not only through elections but also through how it responds when citizens gather to dissent. The massive youth-led protests in Delhi demanding the resignation of Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan have become far more than an agitation over examination irregularities. They have evolved into a defining moment in the relationship between the Indian state and its young citizens. While the Delhi Police has denied allegations of excessive force, countless videos circulating across social media appear to show baton charges, tear gas, forcible detentions and chaotic confrontations with protesters. Those images, regardless of competing official narratives, have shifted the national conversation. The issue is no longer confined to leaked examinations or ministerial accountability. It is now about the constitutional right to peaceful assembly, the proportional use of police power and the willingness of governments to engage with dissent instead of attempting to suppress it.

The immediate trigger for the protests was familiar. Another major examination allegedly compromised by paper leaks has reinforced the perception that India's competitive examination system is failing the very students it is meant to serve. For millions of young Indians, these examinations determine access to higher education, careers and economic mobility. When such tests lose credibility, the damage extends far beyond administrative embarrassment. It strikes at public faith in meritocracy. Reports linking examination chaos to severe mental distress and student suicides have intensified public anger. The hunger strike undertaken by education activist Sonam Wangchuk further transformed what might have remained an isolated education issue into a larger moral campaign. The emergence of the Cockroach Janata Party (CJP), initially born from satire but rapidly evolving into a youth mobilisation platform, demonstrates how quickly frustration can crystallise into organised political action when conventional channels of grievance redressal appear ineffective. Governments often underestimate the speed with which digitally connected generations convert shared outrage into collective action.

Equally troubling has been the state's response. Delhi Police prohibited the march, imposed restrictions on gatherings, erected barricades and reportedly suspended internet services in parts of the capital. Such measures may be justified by authorities on grounds of maintaining public order, particularly if intelligence inputs indicate the possibility of violence. The state unquestionably possesses both the authority and responsibility to prevent lawlessness. Yet democratic policing requires proportionality. Restrictions cannot become substitutes for engagement, nor can force become the default language of governance. The Delhi Police has categorically rejected allegations of brutality, and every claim must ultimately be tested through impartial investigation rather than social media alone. Nevertheless, when multiple videos from different locations consistently depict officers using batons, firing tear gas and dragging protesters, public confidence inevitably demands more than official denials. Transparency is essential. Independent scrutiny of police conduct, body-camera footage where available and judicial oversight can establish facts more credibly than competing political narratives. Democracies are strengthened not by denying allegations but by investigating them openly.

History repeatedly demonstrates that governments rarely emerge stronger by appearing intolerant of peaceful protest, especially when the protesters are students. Universities and campuses have long served as incubators of democratic participation. Student movements have shaped politics across continents, sometimes imperfectly but often profoundly. India itself has witnessed transformative youth mobilisations, from the JP Movement of the 1970s to anti-corruption campaigns and citizenship protests in more recent years. Not every protest is correct in its demands, and no movement should enjoy immunity from lawful regulation. Yet the legitimacy of democratic dissent rests precisely on allowing citizens to voice grievances without fear of excessive coercion. Images of young people confronting riot police resonate far beyond the immediate dispute because they evoke larger anxieties about shrinking civic space. Even governments with overwhelming electoral mandates must remember that constitutional legitimacy depends not only upon winning elections but also upon respecting rights between elections.

The political consequences of this confrontation may extend well beyond education policy. India possesses one of the world's youngest populations. This demographic dividend has frequently been celebrated as the country's greatest strategic advantage. Yet demographic strength becomes political vulnerability if aspirations remain unmet. Young Indians increasingly confront uncertain employment prospects, intense competition, rising educational costs and persistent concerns about examination integrity. These structural frustrations cannot be dispersed with barricades or internet shutdowns. They require institutional reforms that restore trust. That begins with making examination systems tamper-proof, ensuring swift accountability when leaks occur, strengthening independent recruitment agencies and establishing transparent mechanisms for investigating allegations. Equally important is creating channels through which students can engage policymakers before anger reaches the streets. A democracy confident in itself has little reason to fear dialogue with its youth.

Ultimately, today's confrontation presents a choice that extends beyond one minister, one protest or one police action. It asks whether governments will interpret public dissent as a threat to authority or as an opportunity to correct institutional failures. It also asks whether policing in democratic India will increasingly prioritise de-escalation over confrontation. The Constitution guarantees freedom of speech and peaceful assembly not because protests are convenient but because they are essential safeguards against governmental complacency. Where violence occurs, the law must intervene firmly. But where peaceful citizens assemble to demand accountability, the state's first instinct should be conversation, not coercion. The videos from Delhi—whatever final investigations conclude about individual incidents—have already become symbols of a deeper unease between India's rulers and its youth. That unease cannot be resolved through official statements alone. It demands credible accountability, institutional reform and, above all, the humility to recognise that sometimes the loudest lesson for a government comes not from Parliament but from the streets outside it.

DEMOCRATIC
IDEALS



JOHN FELIX RAJ & PRABHAT KUMAR DATTA

FELIX RAJ IS THE VICE CHANCELLOR, PRABHAT KUMAR DATTA IS AN ADJUNCT PROFESSOR, BOTH AT ST. XAVIER'S UNIVERSITY, KOLKATA

US finds itself at a profound crossroads: grappling with the enduring revolutionary ideals of 1776 on one hand, and the stark, complex realities of its domestic and global power on the other

Ideas, Power and Paradox

The American Revolution transformed politics, economics and democracy worldwide, but America's 250th year raises difficult questions about its founding ideals

The American Revolution of 1775 was a monumental watershed in global history. What began as a localised protest against British taxes levied without colonial representation quickly escalated into a full-scale rebellion against the British monarchy and Parliament. Armed with resolve—and crucial military assistance from France—the American colonies achieved the unthinkable: defeating the global superpower of the day. Significantly, this seismic political shift coincided with an intellectual one; in 1776, Adam Smith published his groundbreaking economic treatise, *The Wealth of Nations*, signalling the twin birth of modern political and economic liberty.

The Declaration of Independence
On June 7, 1776, Richard Henry Lee introduced a motion for independence before the Second Continental Congress. Four days later, a committee was formed to draft a document articulating the colonies' grievances and justifying their separation from Great Britain. Drafted primarily by Thomas Jefferson and famously signed by John Hancock, the Declaration of Independence was adopted on July 4, 1776, officially naming the new nation the United States of America.

This declaration differed fundamentally from the French Revolution of 1789 and subsequent anti-colonial movements. The American revolutionaries were, in essence, transplanted Europeans—or, as Thomas Paine aptly wrote in 1776, the "colony of all Europe" (later echoed by Charles de Gaulle in 1965, who characterised America as the "daughter of Europe"). This unique lineage led philosopher Hannah Arendt to observe:

"Neither the spirit of [the American] Revolution nor the thoughtful and erudite political theories of the Founding Fathers had much noticeable impact upon the European continent."

The Consequences of the Revolution
The Revolution fundamentally challenged the core assumptions of hereditary monarchy: hierarchy, structural inequality, devotion to kinship, patriarchy, and patronage. Instead, it unleashed the aspirations of thousands of "middling" people—commercial farmers, petty merchants, and small-scale traders—who sought to improve their lives through free enterprise. In doing so, they laid the groundwork



for a capitalist, democratic society unlike anything the world had ever seen.

For the Western world, this marked a new dawn:

Political Justice: Democracy became explicitly bound to the concept of political justice.

Universal Rights: The Declaration forged an enduring alliance between democracy and modern freedom by asserting that all human beings are, by nature, free and equal, and that governments derive their "just powers from the consent of the governed."

Global Echoes: The American model catalysed constitutionalism abroad. The Mexican Constitution drew heavily from the U.S. framework. Furthermore, as historian Brian DeLay has noted, American-manufactured guns and gunpowder actively fueled the Spanish American wars of independence, as well as the Haitian Revolution.

Social and Political Transformations
The events of 1776 triggered profound internal social changes:

Democratic Expansion: Suffrage was gradually extended.

Abolition of Feudal Vestiges: Aristocratic practices such as primogeniture and entail were abolished.

Secularisation: The Anglican Church was disestablished.

Redistribution: Loyalist estates were confiscated and redistributed.

Slavery: The Revolution ignited the first legislative steps toward ending slavery and the slave trade in several Northern states.

In 1776, America became more than just a democracy; it became a republic. At the time, republicanism did not dictate a rigid structure of government. Instead, it was a spirit—a set of shared values shaping

civic culture. Jefferson reverently referred to this ideology as "the holy republican gospel."

As the first large-scale republic since antiquity, the United States stood as a beacon during the revolutionary waves that swept the Atlantic world from South America to Eastern Europe through the mid-19th century.

This republican ideology also fueled a wave of humanitarianism, encouraging citizens to reform institutions (such as prisons and penal codes) and improve public morality (through movements such as temperance). It sparked a massive reawakening of pietistic religion and gave rise to a defining American phenomenon: the voluntary association. By the 1830s, French political theorist Alexis de Tocqueville famously observed that these self-organised civic groups formed the very epicenter of American civil society.

Furthermore, the geopolitical shift brought about by the Revolution had complex global ripple effects. Proponents argue that, without the rise of an independent United States to challenge British hegemony, the plight of Native Americans might have been no better, the British emancipation of enslaved people in the West Indies could have been significantly delayed, and the rights of British colonists worldwide would have remained severely restricted.

From Isolationism to Global Intervention
Following the counsel of George Washington, the early United States initially pursued a foreign policy of isolationism and neutrality. However, this stance quickly gave way to continental expansion. Critics point out that, while America did not

conquer traditional overseas colonies, it operated as a settler-colonial power—first expanding across North America and later extending its sphere of influence into Central America and the Caribbean.

In the modern era, U.S. foreign policy has faced severe criticism. In regions such as the Horn of Africa, the U.S. has frequently been accused of prioritising its own security and geopolitical objectives over human rights, sometimes backing autocratic regimes and advocating economic structural adjustments that gutted vital public services.

Many scholars trace the formalisation of covert U.S. intervention to the creation of the Central Intelligence Agency (CIA) in 1947. In 1953, the CIA, alongside Britain's MI6, orchestrated a coup against Mohammad Mosaddegh, Iran's democratically elected Prime Minister. Similar interventions followed in Vietnam and Chile.

Modern Conflicts: Decades later, armed interventions and targeted military operations against foreign heads of state continue to shape the controversial legacy of U.S. power abroad.

A Semiquincentennial Crisis: The Erosion of Democracy

As the United States marks its 250th anniversary, researchers and political analysts warn of a historic crisis defined by severe polarisation, institutional decay, and threats to fundamental checks and balances.

There is growing concern that the nation is slipping from a robust liberal democracy to a mere electoral democracy. Analysts point to executive aggrandisement, the erosion of civil liberties, and highly partisan gerrymandering—which critics warn could drastically reduce minority representation in Congress—as symptoms of a deeper systemic decline.

According to data from the V-Dem (Varieties of Democracy) Institute, the United States has recently lost key attributes of a healthy liberal democracy, including strong constraints on executive overreach and institutional safeguards designed to prevent the tyranny of the majority.

As the nation celebrates its milestone 250th year, it finds itself at a profound crossroads: grappling with the enduring revolutionary ideals of 1776 on one hand, and the stark, complex realities of its domestic and global power on the other.

Views expressed are personal

SAFE
HARVEST



SUNITA NARAIN

THE WRITER IS THE DIRECTOR-GENERAL OF CSE AND EDITOR OF DOWNTOEARTH

Passing stronger regulations is only the first step. Their effectiveness will depend on regular residue testing, accredited laboratories, traceability systems, independent certification, and stricter surveillance

Prescription for Safer Food

India's export-driven reforms should become a nationwide public health mission ensuring cleaner food, lower antibiotic resistance and greater consumer confidence everywhere

A few years ago, the EU issued directives on the use of antibiotics in the food it imports. This meant animal products, including fish, dairy and honey, produced using antibiotics as growth promoters or to increase yield would not be allowed into the bloc. It also put out a list of antibiotics, deemed critical for humans, which would be banned for veterinary use. When this was released in 2023, India was omitted from the list of countries allowed to export aquaculture and poultry products to the EU from September 2026, when the directive would come into force. This was done, according to the EU, because of lack of information and regulations on the use of antibiotics in India's food-producing sectors.

The Indian government responded. In October 2024, the Food Safety and Standards Authority of India (FSSAI) published a list of antibiotics banned for use at any stage of the production of meat, milk, poultry, eggs and aquaculture products. It also set tolerance limits—also called Maximum Residue Limit (MRL)—for antibiotics that were permissible, requiring producers to ensure that residues in food did not exceed stipulated thresholds. In May 2025, the Union health ministry issued a draft notification banning the veterinary use of 34 of the 37 antibiotics that the EU classifies as critical for humans. It was not



Food safety should be driven by public health, not merely by the requirements of foreign markets

fied in September that year and stated that safer alternatives were available for treating diseases in animals. In May 2026, the EU revised its exclusion list and added India to the list of countries permitted to export animal products to the bloc after September 2026.

The questions I would like to discuss with you are as follows:

One, why do such critical policies related to food safety and public health have to be driven by external consumer pressure? Antibiotic resistance is a silent pandemic, and we know that the Indian government is deeply committed to the issue. We as a country cannot afford the health burden of lifesaving medicines becoming ineffective and hence, the government has been taking steps to contain the use of antibiotics in food-producing

animals. In 2010, based on an analytical study by the Centre for Science and Environment (CSE), the government issued an advisory against the use of antibiotics in honey, which was later followed by a ban. In 2019, it banned the use of colistin in food-producing animals and in aquaculture—this is because colistin is the top-reserved antibiotic for humans and needs full protection against overuse. Then policymakers were contemplating bans on antibiotics in animal feed and other steps but stopped short of adopting a comprehensive framework. This was finally done, prodded by the need to protect our export markets. What is good is that these regulations are not just for food destined for the EU, but will also apply to the meat, milk, eggs, honey and fish sold within India. It will pro-

tect our health.

The issue is not just about antibiotic use; it is about the safety of the food we consume. We need robust standards for pesticide residues, food additives and other toxins—not just to ensure that India's food is good for export but also to protect our health. A quick dive into the US Food and Drug Administration's import refusal database shows that some 2,700 food consignments from India were rejected in 2024-25. These included spices, rice, pulses and lentils, flagged for excessive or unapproved pesticide residues.

This leads to the next question: how will these standards be enforced? Importing countries have developed monitoring systems based on quality and residue checks in authorised laboratories and even at

their borders. The EU plans to ensure compliance with its directive by asking every single shipment to have a health certificate, issued by a government agency and not by the company exporting the food item. It will also conduct audits in exporting countries and spot checks at the border. The system is designed to push the red button and ratchet up the numbers of physical inspection if one item fails the analytic check; multiple failures could lead to serious consequences. But what about the food that is not exported?

The third question is, how can farmers remain productive without the use of antibiotics—or for that matter, pesticides and other toxins? Ultimately, this is not just a regulatory challenge; it requires changes in the way food is grown. Farmers use antibiotics for three purposes—to promote growth in animals; to prevent diseases because of lack of hygiene or because of high density of animals; and then to treat diseases. Now farmers will need to prevent diseases, not by using antibiotics but by improving conditions in which animals are bred and food is produced. The National Dairy Development Board (NDDB) has worked with its farmers to promote ethnomedicine—traditional practices for managing animal health—and showed it is possible to reduce the use of antibiotics. This is the win-win we need in our world.

Views expressed are personal

TEHRAN RETALIATES AGAINST GULF STATES

US bombing of Iran expands as American troops killed

DUBAI: The United States conducted a new round of air-strikes early Monday targeting Iran after announcing the death of another American service member, hitting around a northwestern city believed to be home to underground missile bases.

Iran responded by launching an attack targeting Bahrain, the home of the US Navy's 5th Fleet, and Kuwait.

The latest attacks again showed how, step by step, the US and Iran have inched closer to all-out war. Last month's interim deal meant to permanently end the fighting has crumbled and shipping traffic in the Strait of Hormuz has largely stalled. Both sides have targeted civilian infrastructure relied on by millions of people.

The escalation in fighting has pushed oil prices higher. Benchmark Brent crude rose Monday above USD 90 a barrel and regular gasoline in the US climbed to an average of USD 4 a gallon, putting pressure on



Representative Image

PHOTO CREDIT: ANI/REUTERS

Americans' wallets ahead of mid-term elections this fall.

The US military said the service member was killed in Iraq on Saturday during the "controlled detonation" of a downed Iranian drone.

"We hit them very hard again tonight," US President Donald Trump said. "And we did that in honour of" the sol-

diers killed, he said.

The US military's Central Command announced a new round of strikes early Monday, now into their ninth straight night. Central Command said it targeted "Iranian military command centres, air defence and coastal surveillance sites, maritime capabilities, missile and drone launch sites and

Highlights

- » Iran responded by launching an attack targeting Bahrain, the home of the US Navy's 5th Fleet, and Kuwait
- » The latest attacks again showed how, step by step, the US and Iran have inched closer to all-out war
- » Both sides have targeted civilian infrastructure relied on by millions of people

communications networks".

Iran's state-run IRNA news agency reported that the American strikes killed at least one person around Tabriz, a northwestern city about 520 km from the capital, Tehran.

Tabriz is believed to host underground missile bases run by Iran's paramilitary Revolutionary Guard. AGENCIES

Andy Burnham: New PM promising stability, national sense of unity in UK

Burnham takes charge as Prime Minister, pledges 'circuit-breaker' moment

LONDON: Andy Burnham began his tenure as the UK's new Prime Minister on Monday with an acknowledgement of the political instability that brought him to the famous black door of 10 Downing Street as the country's seventh leader in a decade.

"I am acutely conscious that I am the sixth person in the last 10 years to walk up this street, the seventh Prime Minister since 2016, making this a moment for reflection and new resolution," Burnham admitted in his inaugural address to the nation as PM soon after a customary meeting with King Charles III.

"It requires my generation of politicians to raise our game and rise to the new challenge. Britain needs to show the world that we can regain our stability once again, and that is our challenge, to make politics work, to make it work better... Let's build a new national sense of unity, of common purpose, and positivity," he declared.

As a visual nod to his pledge to do things differently, the new



Britain's new PM Andy Burnham and his wife Marie-France van Heel wave as they arrive at 10 Downing Street in London on Monday AP/PTI

leader spoke extempore and without the traditional lectern that has been a quintessential feature of prime ministerial speeches at Downing Street over the years. "I know people at home are fed up with politics. I hear you, and I want to be honest with you, we have not been good enough, and we need to be better. We will be," he said. The speech touched upon some of the central tenets

“IT REQUIRES MY GENERATION OF POLITICIANS TO RAISE OUR GAME AND RISE TO THE NEW CHALLENGE”

of his leadership, with devolution of power to the regions of the country and tackling the

cost-of-living crisis at the core. "We will take power out of here and carry it into every postcode in the land so that they can do more. And in doing more, build a new economy, where we put life's essentials back under stronger public control to make them affordable to you again," pledged Burnham. This week marks a case of third time lucky for the 56-year-old former mayor of Greater Manchester, who finally made it to the top job after two failed attempts in 2010 and 2015. As someone who led a major delegation to India in 2019 in his previous avatar, Burnham's commitment to growing the region's ties with India is expected to translate at the national level too.

"India is a key market in Greater Manchester's internationalisation strategy as it presents significant opportunities to the city-region, but these opportunities are mutual, and Greater Manchester is also helping India with its own economic growth plans," he said at the time. AGENCIES

Ukraine fires 400 drones toward Moscow

As Zelenskyy grapples with protests

MOSCOW: Ukraine fired more than 400 drones toward Moscow in its latest major attack on the Russian capital, the city's mayor said Monday.

The blitz came hours after Russia bombed Kyiv and other Ukrainian cities with ballistic missiles in a relentless cycle of tit-for-tat strikes that make a settlement to end Moscow's more than 4-year-old all-out invasion appear a distant possibility.

Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy, meanwhile, said he would hold "key talks" on Monday as he tries to defuse a domestic political crisis, after last week's government reshuffle exposed a deep

The blitz came hours after Russia bombarded Kyiv and other Ukrainian cities with missiles

split between the military's old guard and young innovators over how to fight the war.

Zelenskyy needs to reassure Ukrainians that sacrificing 35-year-old Mykhailo Fedorov as defence minister and keeping faith with 60-year-old Soviet-trained Gen. Oleksandr Syrskyy as armed forces chief won't derail the fight against Russia. AGENCIES

Nepal to mint new coins, removes controversial map

KATHMANDU: The Nepal government has approved minting newly designed coins, removing the country's controversial map that included Limpiyadhura, Lipulek and Kalapani from the one-rupee coin.

Nepal claims that Lipulekh and Kalapani are its territories, whereas India maintains that the territories belong to it.

Nepal's then K P Oli-led government in May 2020 included the territories, including Kalapani and Lipulekh, in its official map.

Sources said the Council of Ministers on Thursday approved the minting of newly designed one-rupee and two-rupee coins by the NRB. AGENCIES

Houthis say they'll block Saudi shipping at Red Sea gateway



Yemen issues warning to Saudi Arabia

CAIRO: Yemen's Iranian-backed Houthi rebels on Monday announced they are imposing a maritime embargo against Saudi Arabia in retaliation for a blockade on Yemen and a recent attack on Sanaa International Airport, threatening another vital waterway for global shipping and raising fears of renewed conflict.

A Houthi military spokesperson, Yahya Saree, said in a video statement that the maritime ban against Saudi Arabia will be effective immediately, describing it as an "equation of an eye for an eye."

There were few details, but the deputy head of the Houthi media office, Nasruddin Amer,

said on X that the Bab al-Mandeb strait will be closed in response to what he called Saudi Arabia's "unjust blockade on Yemenis for over 10 years."

Bab el-Mandeb, at the southern tip of the Arabian

Peninsula, is the gateway to the Red Sea through which around 12 per cent of the world's trade usually passes.

A fourth of global container trade transits through the 32-kilometre (20-mile)-wide strait to and from the Suez Canal.

The Houthis earlier demonstrated their ability to disrupt shipping there when they targeted ships for months over the Israel-Hamas war in Gaza, with over 100 vessels attacked. It is unclear whether the Houthis will resume that level of attack against neighbouring Saudi Arabia.

There was no immediate response from Saudi Arabia. AGENCIES

AHEAD OF NEW SCHOOL YEAR

France moves to ban social media for under-15

PARIS: French lawmakers are racing against the clock to reach a compromise that would allow a bill banning social media for children under 15 to possibly enter into force at the start of the new school year in September.

With Parliament's summer recess looming, time is running out.

Seven members of the National Assembly and seven senators were set to meet on Monday in a joint committee to seek an agreement that could be voted on later this week.

The European Commission has found that the latest version of the bill was not fully compatible with EU law. AGENCIES

French President Emmanuel Macron has strongly backed the ban, which could become one of the final major measures adopted under his leadership before he leaves office next year.

The main point of divergence between the National Assembly and the Senate concerns the scope of the platforms to be banned.

The National Assembly voted to prohibit all online social networking services, whereas the senators wanted to establish a blacklist.

The ban won't cover online encyclopedias, educational or scientific directories, or platforms for the development and sharing of open-source software. AGENCIES

Business

‘Target of 20% ethanol blending met early, saving ₹1.97L cr in forex’

The minister also stated in his written reply that this success is due to the govt's hard work over more than 20 years, MoS Suresh Gopi said

SIMONTINI BHATTACHARJEE

NEW DELHI: India has met the goal of 20 per cent blending of ethanol five years before the expected time as communicated by the Government of India to the Parliament on Monday.

India has set a record for itself by meeting the above goal, which reflects efforts in reducing dependency on foreign crude oil and developing clean fuel options, the Minister of State for the Petroleum and Natural Gas Ministry, Suresh Gopi, informed the Upper House. The minister also stated in his written reply that this success is due to the government's hard work over more than 20 years.

The economic and environmental advantages of the ethanol blending scheme were also pointed out by the government. Starting from ESY 2014-15, through this scheme, savings of foreign exchange to the tune of more than Rs 1.97 lakh crore, saving of nearly 316 lakh metric tonnes of crude oil, saving



of approximately 952 lakh metric tonnes of CO2 emissions, and earning of more than Rs 1.66 lakh crore have been made in favor of Indian farmers, the junior minister informed the Floor of House.

He further underlined that the Centre has not faced any allegations in respect of E20 petrol related to any kind of performance issue such as engine malfunction, fuel pumps malfunction, corrosion of vehicles, or contamination of water in the vehicle. While responding to an unstarred question raised by the CPI(M) member of parliament, John Brittas, regarding the effect of ethanol blended petrol on the perfor-

HIGHLIGHTS

- » The economic and environmental advantages of the ethanol blending scheme were also pointed out by the government
- » Centre has not faced any allegations in respect of E20 petrol related to any kind of performance issue
- » 'Govt has not received any widespread or substantiated complaints from vehicle manufacturers'

mance of vehicles, Gopi stated that the government had found out that there were "no widespread issues" concerning ethanol blending through scientific validation, field tests, information from manufacturers and experience of crores of vehicles.

The minister, however, admitted that "certain concerns raised in media and social media have been considered after consulting with automobile manufacturers and relevant technical bodies."

"The government has not received any widespread or substantiated complaints from vehicle manufacturers, automobile associations or consumer groups on engine failures, fuel

pump problems, corrosion, water contamination or other issues relating to E20 fuel," Gopi said in his written response.

"The problems mentioned in the public domain have been 'scientifically tested', but the extensive research carried out in laboratories as well as field tests done by various organizations like the Automotive Research Association of India (ARAI), Society of Indian Automobile Manufacturers (SIAM), Indian Oil Corporation Limited (IOCL), Indian Institute of Petroleum (IIP) and automobile manufacturers have found no adverse effect on the performance of vehicles," junior petroleum minister stated.

According to the government at the centre, these tests involved various factors, such as durability of engines, drivability, startability, anti-corrosion properties, material compatibility, emissions, and fuel efficiency.

"Extensive laboratory studies, field validation and operational experience of the E20 fuel do not show any adverse effect on the performance of the vehicles," the Minister noted.

On the request for providing the data in terms of complaints received every year state-wise over the last three years, the response was provided as "Nil" since there has not been any widespread and genuine complaint against E20 from the concerned stakeholders as mentioned in the question.

As per the Ministry of Petroleum, the roll-out of the EBP has been done in a phased manner with consultations with NITI Aayog, automobile companies, Oil Marketing Companies (OMCs), ARAI, SIAM, IIP and other technical institutes.

India joins WTO's pact on fisheries subsidies to curb illegal fishing aid

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: India on Monday announced that it has joined the WTO's agreement on fisheries subsidies, which prohibits government support to illegal fishing activities and over-exploitation of stocks.

The agreement focuses on subsidies related to marine wild capture fishing and fishing-related activities at sea.

However, aquaculture and inland fisheries remain outside the scope of this pact, which came into force on September 15, 2025.

The agreement was adopted by consensus at the 12th WTO Ministerial Conference in Geneva in June 2022. It is the first multilateral WTO agreement with an environmental sustainability objective.

"India deposited its Instrument of Acceptance of the WTO Agreement on Fisheries Subsidies (AFS) on 20th July 2026, thereby becoming a Party to the Agreement," the commerce ministry said in a statement.

The formal acceptance was handed over by the Commerce Secretary Rajesh Agrawal to the Director-General of the World Trade Organisation (WTO) Ngozi Okonjo-Iweala in Geneva.

Agarwal is in Geneva for an official visit.

The agreement, it said,



protects the livelihoods of traditional and small-scale fishers by promoting sustainable fisheries.

It prohibits subsidies linked to illegal, unreported and unregulated (IUU) fishing and fishing of overfished stocks, as it aims to address unsustainable fishing practices that threaten marine resources.

The pact also creates a more equitable global fisheries regime by disciplining harmful subsidies that support large, heavily subsidised industrial fishing fleets being operated by distant water fishing nations.

"This benefits countries like India, where fisheries are predominantly small-scale and which are not major participants in industrial fishing," it said, adding that the predominance of aquaculture-based shrimp in India's seafood

exports, which fall outside the scope of the agreement, ensures the continued resilience and competitiveness of the country's seafood export sector.

The pact also seeks to promote the conservation and sustainable use of marine fisheries resources while providing appropriate flexibilities for developing and least-developed country members.

It added that India's domestic fisheries management framework is in alignment with the agreement and safeguards the interests of traditional and small-scale fishers.

The agreement entered into force only after two-thirds of WTO members (166 at present) deposited their instruments of acceptance.

Once that threshold was reached, the pact became legally effective for those countries that had accepted it. PTI

IndiGo to place order for over 1,000 aircraft engines with CFM International

The order will also be the 'largest single order ever placed for LEAP engines and a record for CFM International,' a release said

NEW DELHI: The country's largest airline IndiGo on Monday announced it will place an order with CFM International for more than 1,000 engines to power its 510 A320 neo family planes.

IndiGo and CFM International, an equal joint venture between GE Aerospace and Saf-

ran Aircraft Engines, have inked a Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) for the order at the Farnborough International Airshow in the UK.

The order for more than 1,000 LEAP-1A engines to power 510 Airbus A320 neo family aircraft will also be the "largest single order ever

placed for LEAP engines and a record for CFM International," a release said on Monday.

A320 neo family planes include A320 neos, A321 neos and A321 XLRs. All are narrow-body aircraft.

CFM International would also provide extensive support to the airline in establishing its

engine MRO (Maintenance, Repair and Overhaul) facility in Bengaluru.

Besides, it will provide support to the IndiGo fleet through long-term material services agreement, including supply of spare parts.

Currently, IndiGo has an operational fleet of over 400

planes and over 900 Airbus aircraft are on order.

"CFM has been a trusted partner in our growth journey since 2016, supporting a fleet that now exceeds 375 A320/321Family aircraft. The LEAP engine's industry-leading proven reliability makes it the ideal choice to support our

scale, operational resilience and sustainability ambitions," IndiGo CEO Designate Willie Walsh said.

IndiGo has been a customer of CFM International for 10 years. In 2016, the airline operating a sub-fleet of Airbus A320 neo family aircraft powered by CFM56-5B engines and in 2019,

the airline ordered LEAP-1A engines for their newest fleet of Airbus A320/321 neo family aircraft.

India is the third largest market for CFM International, with 5 Indian carriers operating more than 400 LEAP-powered aircraft and 2,000 engines on order.

GE Aerospace Chairman and CEO H Lawrence Culp, Jr said that with a strong installed base, manufacturing in Pune, a broad local supplier network, and advanced engineering in Bengaluru, we remain committed to supporting IndiGo's growth and expanding our presence in India. PTI

‘Centre’s effective capex rises to ₹90.87L cr during 2014-26’

Govt’s direct capex rose to Rs 64.70 lakh cr from Rs 12.39 lakh cr over the same periods, Finance Ministry said

NEW DELHI: The Centre’s effective capital expenditure rose to Rs 90.87 lakh crore during 2014-26, more than five times the Rs 17.04 lakh crore recorded during 2004-14, while the government’s direct capital expenditure increased to Rs 64.70 lakh crore from Rs 12.39 lakh crore over the same periods, the Finance Ministry informed Parliament on Monday.

In a statement tabled in response to a starred question in the Lok Sabha, Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman said the Centre’s capital expenditure during 2004-14 stood at Rs 12.39 lakh crore, compared with Rs 64.70 lakh crore during 2014-26, adding that the figure for FY2025-26 is provisional.

The government explained that “effective capital expenditure refers to expenditure of Central Government for asset creation and includes grants-in-aid provided to the State Governments for creation of assets such as school buildings under Samagra Shiksha, houses under PM Awas Yojana, etc.”

In simple terms, effective capital expenditure includes not only the Centre’s own spending on creating assets but also the money it gives states specifically for building public infrastructure and other capital assets.



The govt also highlighted that capex as a share of GDP has increased over the years, rising from 1.6 % in FY2014-15 to 3.2% in FY24 & FY25, before moderating marginally to 3.1% in FY26 (provisional)

According to the statement, effective capital expenditure increased to Rs 90.87 lakh crore during 2014-26 from Rs 17.04 lakh crore during 2004-14. Of this, Rs 26.17 lakh crore comprised grants provided to states for creating capital assets, while the remaining Rs 64.70 lakh crore was the Centre’s own capital expenditure.

The government also highlighted that capital expenditure

as a share of GDP has increased over the years, rising from 1.6 per cent in FY2014-15 to 3.2 per cent in FY2023-24 and FY2024-25, before moderating marginally to 3.1 per cent in FY2025-26 (provisional).

Explaining the impact of higher capital spending, the statement said, “The increase in capital expenditure as a percentage of GDP has led to an increase in infrastructure development including roads,

HIGHLIGHTS

- » Effective capex rose to Rs 90.87 lakh cr during FY26 from Rs 17.04 lakh cr during 2004-14
- » Of this, Rs 26.17 lakh crore comprised grants provided to states for creating capital assets
- » Remaining Rs 64.70 lakh crore was the Centre’s own capex
- » ‘The increase in capex as a percentage of GDP has led to an increase in infra development including roads, railways, urban infra, energy and digital connectivity’

railways, urban infrastructure, energy and digital connectivity.” It added that higher public investment has “led to improved logistics efficiency, generated employment and crowded-in private investment.” In simple terms, the government said increased spending on infrastructure has helped improve connectivity, create jobs and encourage private companies to invest alongside public projects. ANI

‘No plan to scrap LTCG tax on equities, govt collected ₹1.29 lakh crore from levy in FY25’

Revenue from LTCG tax transactions stood at Rs 72,249 crore in AY 2024-25 (relevant to FY24) & Rs 1,29,158 crore in AY 2025-26 (relevant to FY25)

NEW DELHI: The government has no proposal to scrap the Long Term Capital Gains (LTCG) tax on equity investments, the Centre informed Parliament on Monday, while disclosing that it collected Rs 1.29 lakh crore from the levy in Assessment Year (AY) 2025-26, up from Rs 72,249 crore in the previous assessment year.

In a written reply to an unstarred question in the Lok Sabha, Minister of State for Finance Pankaj Chaudhary said revenue generated from LTCG tax on equity transactions stood at Rs 72,249 crore in AY 2024-25 (relevant to FY 2023-24) and Rs 1,29,158 crore in AY 2025-26 (relevant to FY 2024-25). The reply added that data for subsequent assessment years is not yet available because income tax returns have not been filed.

Responding to concerns over whether Foreign Portfolio Investors (FPIs) had been given preferential treatment, the government said, “The tax rate of 12.5% on LTCG for domestic and retail investors is the same for FPIs for investments in equity.”

It clarified that the recent tax exemption for FPIs applies only to investments in Government Securities (G-Secs) and not to equity investments. In simple terms, foreign investors continue to pay the same LTCG tax as domestic investors on



Responding to concerns over whether Foreign Portfolio Investors (FPIs) had been given preferential treatment, the government said, ‘The tax rate of 12.5% on LTCG for domestic and retail investors is the same for FPIs for investments in equity’

gains from equities, while only their investments in government bonds have been granted tax exemption.

Explaining the rationale behind the exemption on government securities, the government said it was introduced “recognising the importance of a competitive tax regime in attracting global capital.” It added that the move aims to align India’s taxation of gov-

ernment securities with several comparable jurisdictions and help attract “stable systematic inflow of durable, patient foreign capital” from long-term investors such as pension funds, insurance companies and sovereign wealth funds.

On whether it plans to abolish LTCG tax for retail investors, the government said, “At present, there is no such proposal under consideration.” ANI

HIGHLIGHTS

- » Govt clarified that the recent tax exemption for FPIs applies only to investments in G-Secs & not to equity investments
- » In simple terms, foreign investors continue to pay the same LTCG tax as domestic investors on gains from equities
- » Only the investments by foreign investors in government bonds have been granted tax exemption
- » ‘The tax policies, including capital gains tax rates, are reviewed periodically as part of the annual budgetary process and legislative revisions,’ the govt said

It further noted that “The tax policies, including capital gains tax rates, are reviewed periodically as part of the annual budgetary process and legislative revisions after taking into considerations the macro-economic parameters.” In other words, while capital gains tax rates are reviewed from time to time, there is currently no decision to withdraw the levy on equity investments. ANI

Rupee falls 6 paise to 96.36 against dollar

MUMBAI: The rupee fell 6 paise to 96.36 against the US dollar on Monday, on risk aversion in global markets and a surge in crude oil prices.

Forex traders said escalating US-Iran conflict and rising US Treasury yields weighed on the rupee.

At the interbank foreign exchange, the rupee opened at 96.53 against the US dollar and traded in the range of 96.35 to 96.53 during the day.

The domestic unit finally settled for the day at 96.36, down 6 paise from its previous close.

On Friday, the rupee gained 12 paise to settle at 96.30 against the US dollar.

“We expect the rupee to trade with a negative bias on escalating conflict between the US and Iran over the weekend and elevated crude oil prices. “However, diplomatic talks between the two nations may prevent a sharp fall in the Rupee. Any intervention by the RBI may also support the rupee at lower levels,” Anuj Choudhary, Research Analyst, Mirae Asset ShareKhan.

Meanwhile, the dollar index, which gauges the greenback’s strength against a basket of six currencies, was trading higher by 0.05 per cent at 100.81.

According to the RBI data released on Friday, India’s forex reserves jumped \$964 million to \$675.157 billion in the week ended July 10. In the previous reporting week, the overall kitty had jumped by \$7.26 billion to \$674.193 billion. PTI

Sensex sinks 443 points on selling in HDFC Bank, Axis Bank on margin-related concerns

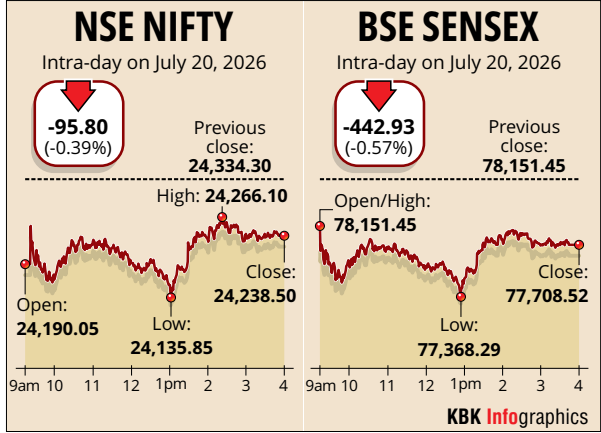
MUMBAI: Benchmark indices Sensex and Nifty closed lower on Monday, dragged down by heavy selling in blue-chip bank stocks HDFC Bank and Axis Bank amid margin-related concerns and a flare-up in US-Iran tensions.

The 30-share BSE Sensex declined 442.93 points, or 0.57 per cent, to settle at 77,708.52. During the day, it tanked 783.16 points, or 1 per cent, to 77,368.29.

The 50-share NSE Nifty edged lower by 95.80 points, or 0.39 per cent, to end at 24,238.50.

Among Sensex shares, Axis Bank was the biggest loser, dropping by 5.48 per cent after its quarterly results over the weekend. HDFC Bank declined by 5.12 per cent.

Maruti, Kotak Mahindra



Bank, Infosys, Tata Consultancy Services, Mahindra & Mahindra and Bharat Electronics were also among the laggards from the blue-chip pack.

Trent, Power Grid, NTPC and Bharti Airtel were among

the gainers.

The global oil benchmark, Brent crude, receded from an early high of \$90 per barrel, later trading lower by 0.05 per cent to \$88.06 per barrel.

Broader markets, however,

Punjab distributes 10,500 safety kits to PSPCL staff

LUDHIANA: Punjab Power Minister Tarunpreet Singh Sondh on Monday launched the distribution of 10,500 safety tool kits for Punjab State Power Corporation Limited (PSPCL) employees, reaffirming the state government’s focus on worker safety.

Speaking at the launch in Ludhiana, Sondh said power employees work in challenging conditions to ensure uninterrupted electricity supply and stressed the need to follow safety protocols to reduce workplace accidents.

He said the government is committed to improving the safety and welfare of power sector employees.

PSPCL CMD Basant Garg



said the utility has spent around Rs 12,000 on each safety kit, taking the total procurement cost to Rs 12.60 crore. He added that employees are also being trained in the proper use of safety equipment.

Each kit includes protective gear and tools such as a safety helmet, pole safety belt, voltage sensor, reflective jacket, safety gloves, goggles, rechargeable LED torch and essential hand tools. MPOST

L&T bags orders of up to ₹15K cr in metals and minerals segment

NEW DELHI: Infrastructure major Larsen & Toubro (L&T) on Monday said it has bagged multiple projects from India’s leading metals and mining companies, including public sector firms.

The mega orders, bagged by the Metals & Minerals (M&M) business vertical of L&T, range between Rs 10,000 crore to Rs 15,000 crore.

The company bagged the first order from a public sector company which is the country’s largest iron ore producer.

The iron ore producer is expanding its operations to achieve an iron ore production capacity of 100 million tonnes per annum (MTPA)

by 2030.

As part of the expansion, the company is building an 18 MTPA Iron Ore Handling Plant in Chhattisgarh.

L&T has been awarded a specific package for this project and will be responsible for the engineering, procurement and construction (EPC).

“As part of its expansion programme to achieve 100 MTPA of iron ore production capacity by 2030, the company has awarded L&T Package...” L&T said in a statement.

The scope includes design and engineering, procurement, installation and commissioning of downhill conveyor sys-

tem, screening plant, stockpile, yard equipment, rapid wagon loading system and associated auxiliaries.

The second order is from another public sector Navratna company, which has undertaken the expansion of a steel plant in West Bengal, from 2.5 MTPA to 7.1 million tonnes per annum.

The company has secured various design and build and balance of plant packages for this.

L&T also continues its longstanding association with a major private sector metals producer, having secured an EPC order for a Zinc processing Plant. MPOST

Core sector output hits 5-month high of 5% in June

The core sectors’ growth was 1.1 per cent in June 2025 and 3.2 per cent in May 2026

NEW DELHI: Production growth of nine core infrastructure sectors rose to a five-month high of 5 per cent in June due to an increase in output of cement, electricity and iron ore, official data released on Monday showed.

The core sectors’ growth was 1.1 per cent in June 2025 and 3.2 per cent in May 2026.

The data has been released with a new base year, 2022-23, replacing the earlier base year of 2011-12.

The government has also added iron ore to the index, increasing the number of core sectors to nine.

CLOSER LOOK

- » According to the official data, production of crude oil, natural gas, refinery products, and fertiliser declined during the month
- » On other hand, production of cement and electricity rose by 9.8% each & of iron ore, which has been included in index under the new series, jumped by 43.9% in June
- » During April-June 2026-27, the key sectors expanded by 3.6 per cent against 1 per cent in the same period last year

According to the official data, production of crude oil, natural gas, refinery products, and fertiliser declined during the month.

On the other hand, production of cement and electricity rose by 9.8 per cent each, and of iron ore, which has been included in the

index under the new series, jumped by 43.9 per cent in June.

Coal output rose by 1.4 per cent in June against a 6.8 per cent contraction in the same month last year. Steel output growth slowed down to 4.6 per cent from 10.2 per cent in June 2025.

During April-June 2026-27, the key sectors expanded by 3.6 per cent against 1 per cent in the same period last year.

The commerce and industry ministry, in a statement, said that owing to intensive use of iron ore in the production process and its contribution to

industrial development, it has been included in the list of core industries as a new item in the revised series.

Commenting on the data, ICRA Ltd said the pickup in June was not broad-based and was led by an improvement in the performance of just four of the nine sectors.

It added that fertiliser output contracted for the fourth consecutive month, likely reflecting the continued adverse impact of the West Asia tensions, while the growth in steel output slumped to a 21-month low of 4.6 per cent in the month. PTI

MUMBAI: The RBI on Monday said its concessional swap facility, introduced to encourage foreign currency inflows, has attracted \$20.72 billion till July 17. The swap facility has seen avid interest and attracted steady forex inflows since June 8, 2026, the central bank said in a statement.

A strong mobilisation was witnessed through Foreign Currency Non-Resident (Bank) or FCNR (B) deposits.

Of the total inflows, FCNR (B) deposits accounted for \$17.406 billion, while Overseas Foreign Currency Borrowings (OFCBs) contributed \$1.97 bil-

lion and External Commercial Borrowings (ECBs) amounted to \$1.342 billion.

“With a view to strengthening our balance of payments and incentivising capital inflows, the RBI had announced a series of measures, including a facility for offering concessional swaps for fresh FCNR(B) deposits, OFCB and ECB inflows on June 5, 2026,” the central bank said.

The Reserve Bank of India (RBI) had introduced the swap facility on June 5, 2026, as part of a host of measures to strengthen India’s balance of payments and incentivise capital inflows. PTI

The facility was operationalised on June 8, 2026, and is available up to September 30, 2026, for the FCNR (B) deposits and up to December 31, 2026, for the OFCBs and ECBs.

The measures were announced as part of the RBI’s efforts to strengthen India’s external sector position and support foreign exchange liquidity amid global market uncertainties. According to some initial estimates, the schemes could yield inflows of up to \$70 billion in forex through the window, but of late, there have been some voices that have gone public with some doubts. PTI

When Messi looked mortal

Superstar unable to conjure more magic as crown passes to Spain

EAST RUTHERFORD: Lionel Messi could conjure no more magic.

Twenty years after his World Cup debut and a career that lifted him above Pelé and Diego Maradona as soccer's greatest player, at 39 he could not will Argentina to become the first repeat champion in more than a half-century.

Spain outplayed the Albiceleste from the opening whistle at MetLife Stadium, where the overwhelming majority of 80,663 were hoping for a coronation. Ferran Torres scored 37 seconds into the second extra-time period, lifting Spain to a 1-0 victory and its second World Cup title.

Instead of Messi becoming a two-time champion, the crown passed. He fought back tears and had a look of misery as he and teammates faced applauding and bowing Argentina fans at the stadium's south end while Spanish stars lifted the trophy on a podium at the center stripe.

After leading Argentina to victory in the 2022 final against France, sandwiched between consecutive Copa America championships, Messi could only bow his head, grimace and

We gave everything: Scaloni

MADRID: Argentina coach Lionel Scaloni conceded that Spain were the better team in the World Cup final on Sunday but said he was proud of how his players left everything on the pitch despite relinquishing the title. "I feel sad," said Scaloni. "One could say many things about how we got here, but it's not worth it. Endless thanks to these players who once again took us to the final. "If they give everything the way they did today, it sets a great example for the people and for our country. You have to pick yourself up again. When you leave everything like that, it's very hard to find fault with anything."

AGENCIES

put hands on hips as Spain's Lamine Yamal, less than a week past his 19th birthday and projected as the sport's next big thing, ran to embrace Torres after the goal.

"I hope that everyone feels proud of him, of what he's achieved because he's the best football player ever stepping foot on a pitch," Argentina coach Lionel Scaloni said.

Spain's dominance was thorough in the final and throughout the World Cup as they extended their unbeaten streak to 38 games, the longest by a European team.

La Furia Roja had a 20-2 advantage in shots, the second-largest difference in a World Cup final since stats exist since

1966, behind only West Germany outshooting Argentina 23-1 in 1990, according to Opta. They out-passed Argentina 845-433.

They conceded just one goal the entire tournament, the fewest by a World Cup champion, and scored 14 while compiling a 145-45 advantage in shots. Goalkeeper Unai Simon totaled 10 saves over eight games — Argentina's Emiliano Martínez had 11 in the final alone.

When Messi left European soccer for MLS three years ago after four Champions League medals and 12 league titles with Barcelona and Paris Saint-Germain, some speculated he would be another retiree moving to Florida.

Instead, he won a Major League Soccer title with Miami and led Argentina back to the final with eight goals and four assists. He has played in a record 34 World Cup games over six tournaments and boosted career goals total to 21, the record until France's Kylian Mbappé scored twice in Saturday's third-place game to surpass him to 22.

Messi became the first player to start three World Cup finals and raised his international goals total to 125, second only to Cristiano Ronaldo's 146. He is now regularly mentioned in the same breath as Maradona and Pelé, the only three-time World Cup champion.

With his distinctive slow walk, arms swinging at his side as he waited for the right moment to burst into a sprint, the diminutive 5-foot-7 attacker was the center of attention any time he got the ball on the right flank. Opponents and fans waited for him to cut to the center and unleash a shot with his lethal left foot.

Messi had just 15 touches in the first half and 54 over the game at the stadium where he has been repeatedly frustrated.

AGENCIES



Lionel Messi is emotional after the trophy presentation

AP

Royal welcome set for champions

MADRID: Spain's World Cup-winning soccer team is set to return home on Monday, where the 26-man squad will be greeted by Spanish royalty and Prime Minister Pedro Sánchez before boarding an open-top bus for a parade through central Madrid.

Throng of fans will greet them as they travel

from near Moncloa Palace, the prime minister's official residence, to Cibeles Square.

Meanwhile, a 13-year-old died and two people were injured when a fountain partially collapsed in western Spain in the early hours on Monday, marring mass celebrations of the victory, emergency services said.

AGENCIES

4
Argentina have finished as runners-up at the FIFA World Cup for the fourth time

1
Argentina were the first team in FIFA World Cup history not to have a shot in 90 minutes of a FIFA World Cup final

“I hope that everyone feels proud of him, of what he's achieved because he's the best football player ever to set foot on a pitch. I have no doubt

Lionel Scaloni on Messi

RODRI WINS GOLDEN BALL

Mbappe odd one out as La Roja sweep honours



Pau Cubarsi, Rodri and Unai Simon with their individual awards

AP

NEW DELHI: Kylian Mbappé kept the Golden Boot award and Spain wouldn't let Lionel Messi get anything else.

Shortly after winning the World Cup title Sunday, the Spaniards claimed all three individual player awards, keeping Messi from leaving with any more personal hardware.

Rodri won the Golden Ball as the tournament's best player, Unai Simón won the Golden Glove for the top performance by a goalkeeper, and Pau Cubarsi won the Best Young Player Award, beating out fellow 19-year-old teammate Lamine Yamal.

Messi was hoping to win a record-extending third Golden Ball, adding to his 2014 and 2022 honors. He's already the only player to win the award multiple times since it was first given in 1978, and sparking Argentina's run to a second straight final at age 39 gave him a strong case for another.

But the award went to Rodri for captaining Spain's run to its second World Cup title after the Manchester City midfielder struggled early after returning in May 2025 from knee surgery that sidelined him eight months. "For me, it's been a very tough time. I just want the new generation to see my example as an opportunity to that if you go down, you can rise again," he said. "This is

11
Rodri became just the 11th man to win the World Cup, the UEFA Champions League and the Ballon d'Or

my philosophy my entire life. Of course, sometimes things go well, things go wrong. But always the positive."

Rodri had no goals or assists in the tournament, but he was critical to Spain's possession-heavy style of play. He completed more passes than anyone (753) with 94% accuracy. He was involved in 1,803 plays, according to FIFA stats, nearly 200 more than anyone else in this World Cup. "I heard that at the beginning of the tournament I wasn't able to play, now that I recovered my shape. I tried not to listen too much," Rodri said on the eve of the final. "I've always been confident of myself. I think one of the big parts of my game is trying to replicate this accuracy in terms of passing and being very safe with the ball."

AGENCIES

The golden move: How Torres scored the World Cup-winning goal

EAST RUTHERFORD: Ferran Torres delivered Spain the winning goal at the World Cup with a play made possible by two of the team's best players and two who substituted into the final against Argentina on Sunday.

Until that point, Spain put 11 shots on net and could not crack opposing goalkeeper Emiliano "Dibu" Martínez.

"We had many chances," Spain coach Luis de la Fuente said. "But Dibu was nothing short of exceptional."

The teams had played 105 minutes, and Spain looked to get a big advantage when Enzo Fernández was sent off in regular stoppage time with his second yellow card.

Still, playing 11 men against 10, Spain were unable to capitalize on any chances through the first half of extra time, including a disallowed goal when the referee ruled that Mikel Merino stepped on one of Argentina defender Nicolás Otamendi's feet prior to Nico Williams putting the ball into the net. With the score 0-0 coming out of the midway point of extra time, Spain got the ball at midfield. Argentina, playing shorthanded, put up very little resistance.

Pau Cubarsi passed the ball up the field to Marc Cucurella, then Eric García and then up to Martín Zubimendi, who found Yamal on the right. Yamal put a shot on net very early in the



Ferran Torres is off to celebrate after scoring the winner

AP

game and also had another earlier scoring chance, earning the praise of teammates and his coach for being one of the best

on the field at 19 years old.

"He's played great football, a football that will help him to mature and be even a greater

‘My job was easy’: Simon salutes Spain’s record defence

EAST RUTHERFORD: After cruising through the World Cup barely allowing any goals, Spain won the final hardly allowing a shot.

How good was this Spain defense? Take it from their goalkeeper.

"(My hands) didn't really have to work that hard as much as other keepers," Unai Simón said through an interpreter.

Spain's 1-0 victory over Argentina on Sunday was their record seventh shutout of the World Cup. The Spaniards allowed just one goal and in the final permitted just two shots, neither on net.

Spain's 2010 championship team shared the previous record of two goals allowed in a World Cup with two other teams. Iker Casillas, the goalkeeper of the country's first World Cup champions, watched in MetLife Stadium seated with 2010 teammates Xavier Hernández, Andrés Iniesta, Carles Puyol and Sergio Ramos. This squad allowed



Spain's Unai Simon makes a save during their match

AP

“(My hands) didn't really have to work that hard as much as other keepers

Unai Simon

only Belgium to score in a 2-1 quarterfinals victory, then blanked teams featuring Kylian

American makeover leaves soccer facing a battle for its soul

NEW YORK: The 2026 World Cup may ultimately be remembered less for the identity of its winner than for the question it left hanging over the game: how much of soccer's American makeover will survive once the tournament leaves North America?

From mandatory "hydration" breaks that effectively split matches into four quarters to championship rings, a half-time show and an ever more tightly packaged entertainment product, FIFA embraced elements of the U.S. sporting model with enthusiasm. Some of those innovations will probably be remembered as novelties of an American-hosted tournament — while others may prove harder to dislodge.

The mid-half breaks, brought in throughout the competition regardless of whether conditions strictly required them, were introduced by FIFA on player-welfare grounds in a tournament played through the heat and humidity of a North American

The breaks are likely to be discussed for future World Cups

summer.

Once established, they also created something football has traditionally resisted: two scheduled interruptions in the middle of each half. For coaches, they became tactical timeouts. For broadcasters, they offered natural windows that could one day carry enormous commercial value.

Winning team Spain received championship rings, a tradition imported directly from North American sport, while the showpiece final itself featured a major halftime entertainment production that has drawn obvious comparisons with the Super Bowl and led to a 27-minute interval, shooting past the sacrosanct 15-minute halftime period.

Neither changes the abso-

lute fundamentals of the game. But they contributed to a sense that FIFA was no longer merely bringing the World Cup to the United States but increasingly adapting the World Cup to American culture.

There was an irony in that. Across the tournament, American cities experienced much of what has always made international soccer distinct: vast travelling support, flags filling city centres, supporters singing for hours before and after matches and national teams carrying a sense of identity that no franchise model can easily reproduce. The United States appeared to be absorbing the culture of football. At the same time, FIFA seemed intent on absorbing the culture of American sports entertainment and projecting it to fans worldwide.

The tournament was also unavoidably political, with FIFA President Gianni Infantino's close relationship with U.S. President Donald Trump becoming one of its defining off-field themes.

AGENCIES

World Cup final fever empties wallets, fills stands as fans travel miles

EAST RUTHERFORD: Tom Cruise gamely tried to deliver a speech at the World Cup about how soccer was some sort of global unifier and great players had crossed oceans and borders, and, well, what was the rest?

It was about mission impossible to hear the actor over the cacophony of bells and whistles and drums that served as the house band for all the joyous singing and clapping among the Argentine and Spanish fans who traveled thousands of miles — and spent thousands and thousands more in tickets, beers and, yes, wigs — to watch the World Cup final.

No exorbitant ticket price was too high to possibly say goodbye to Lionel Messi, playing in likely his last World Cup game.

"Money comes back," Argentina fan Manuel Lopez Maccotta said. "This is once in a lifetime. You're seeing the best

Sing, stomp, spend



player in the world in his last World Cup. Money is worthless compared to this."

Maccotta and one of his friends traveled from Buenos Aires to New Jersey to watch Spain's 1-0 win over Argentina on Ferran Torres' goal in extra time on Sunday.

The ticket price?

"Almost 10K in American money," Maccotta said.

The \$18 beer he was in line to buy suddenly seemed like chump change compared to the hot game ticket.

His friend Santiago Burcaco got off easy at \$5,000 for

his ticket.

"I bought the ticket before the World Cup final," he said.

In the 200 section of the stadium Sunday, Guadalupe Villar said she and her husband were at the finals almost by chance.

The Buenos Aires couple, who brought along their nearly 2-year-old daughter, won a contest for tickets to Argentina's semifinal match against England in Atlanta. After their home country won, they decided they weren't ready to go home and splurged for finals tickets that cost \$7,000 each (their daughter was free).

"We both work and we have some savings and we were like, OK, maybe this vacation will go a little longer. We're here now, you know?" Villar said.

The only hiccup? Their flight from Atlanta to New York was canceled by bad weather.

Villar, who is an architect, said the family piled into a car with fellow countrymen they

met on their travels and drove the 15 hours north, arriving at 5 a.m. on gameday.

"We're tired, and hot," she said as she took a break in a shaded area between the seating bowl and the concession area with her sleepy daughter.

After the match, the family headed for the exits before the championship trophy was handed to Spain. "Spain was better this game, it hurts me to say," Rodrigo Fernandez said as Villar carried their sleeping daughter. "It was a great game, and it was a shame to lose, but was an unforgettable experience."

Just as they have throughout the tournament, fans from both countries were jacked up from the moment they navigated long times to enter the stadium and sang and chanted in their native languages; certainly, giving performers such as Madonna and Shakira a lofty bar to reach.

AGENCIES

NORTHERN RAILWAY

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The Sr. Divisional Commercial Manager/G, Northern Railway, Delhi Division, New Delhi invites e-Auction through IREPS (<https://ireps.gov.in/>) for allotment of contracts of Water Vending Machines (WVMs) at following railway stations/locations:

Auction Catalogue No. for e-Auction	Date & Time	Cluster No.	No. of WVMs at Railway Stations
CTG-WVM-05-2026	03.08.2026 at 11:00 hrs	D	Total 07 WVMs (03 WVMs at Panipat, 02 WVMs at Samalkha and 02 WVMs Bhowdal Majri Railway Station).
		F	Total 06 WVMs (03 WVMs at Kurukshetra, 02 WVMs at Kamal and 01 WVM at Shahbad Marknda Railway Station).
		E	Total 06 WVMs (02 WVMs at Badli, 02 WVMs at Ganaur and 02 WVMs at Sonipat Railway Station).

Website particulars where complete details of E-Auction can be seen

[https://ireps.gov.in/ \(E-Auction-Leasing\)](https://ireps.gov.in/ (E-Auction-Leasing))

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> Registration on IREPS for E-Auction Leasing module - Active IREPS User Account for E-Auction Leasing Module.

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‘Today is that moment for me’

Yami penned a heartfelt note after winning ‘Best Actress’ National Film Award

Yami Gautam penned a heartfelt note after winning the ‘Best Actress’ award at the 72nd National Film Awards for her performance in ‘Article 370’. The prestigious honour marks one of the biggest milestones in her acting career. Soon after the winners were announced, the actress took to social media to express her gratitude and

reflect on the journey that brought her to this moment.

Opening her message, she wrote, “Every journey has a moment that reminds you why you never gave up. Today is that moment for me. Receiving the National Award for ‘Article 370’ is an honour I will cherish for the rest of my life.”

Reflecting on her career, Yami shared that the award represents the outcome of years of perseverance, dedication and faith in meaningful storytelling. She said she always focused on delivering

sincere performances rather than chasing recognition.

She wrote, “For 14 years, I have simply tried to stay true to my craft, work with honesty and let my performances speak for themselves. This honour feels like the culmination of a journey filled with hope, perseverance, resilience and an unwavering love for cinema. It is a dream I have carried in my heart for years and today, I receive it with immense gratitude and humility (sic).”

Yami revealed that ‘Article 370’ was far more than another acting assignment. Along with portraying intelligence officer Zooni Haksar, she said the film carried emotional significance because it was produced under her home banner. She explained that everyone associated with the project shared a

common vision of telling the story with sincerity and conviction. According to the actress, every discussion, challenge and day on set strengthened that commitment. Yami also thanked the National Film Awards jury, director Aditya Suhas Jambhale, the writers, cast, crew, producers and audiences for believing in the film. She said the response to ‘Article 370’ reinforced her confidence that meaningful stories continue to resonate with viewers across the country.

In her message, Yami expressed heartfelt gratitude to her family, friends and professional team for standing by her throughout every phase of her career. She credited their encouragement for giving her the confidence to keep moving forward during difficult periods.

She added, “This award is not the end of a dream; it is the beginning of a greater responsibility. To keep growing, to keep taking risks and to keep telling stories that matter (sic).”

Ending her note on an inspiring note, Yami encouraged aspiring artists to continue believing in themselves. She added, “Dreams do come true but only when passion refuses to give up.” AGENCIES



‘Receiving the National Award for ‘Article 370’ is an honour I will cherish for the rest of my life’



‘It will take at least three years for another film’

LOS ANGELES: Film-maker Christopher Nolan said it will take him at least three years for another film after his latest release ‘The Odyssey’.

“I definitely hit the limits of my own stamina and everybody’s stamina, I think... I mean, it’s ‘The Odyssey’, of course it should be difficult. We’re not doing the job right making a film of ‘The Odyssey’ if it doesn’t seem difficult,” he told Today in an interview.

The filmmaker recalled telling cast and crew about making the film with IMAX cameras. “If ever we are going to fulfil this dream of shooting the entire movie that way, this is the one. This is ‘The Odyssey’,” he said.

‘The Odyssey’ in 1997 was directed by Andrei Konchalovsky and was broadcast as a two-part miniseries. It starred Armand Assante as the Greek king and Greta Scacchi as Penelope and followed Odysseus’s perilous 10-year journey home after the Trojan War. PFI

Kajal talks about judgement actresses face for ‘bold’ scenes

Ahead of the release of ‘Toxic’, the makers unveiled the song ‘Tabaahi’, featuring Yash and Kiara Advani. The music video drew criticism on social media over its steamy scenes. While both actors appeared in the intimate sequences, much of the backlash was directed at Kiara. Amid the backlash, actress Kajal Aggarwal responded to a question about why female actors are often criticised for doing ‘bold’ scenes, particularly after marriage. In contrast, male actors rarely face similar scrutiny.

During an interview with Shubhankar Mishra, Kajal was asked why men and women are often judged differently for performing intimate scenes on screen. The actress replied, “I think it becomes a personal choice. A man should use his brain and make a choice if he wants to do it or not. It should come from inside that I don’t want to do it. Women are more cautious about it.”

Speaking about her own personal preference, she said, “I can only speak about myself. I have never done such roles. I have never been up for intimacy on screen or wearing anything that I am not comfortable with - for example, a



bikini on screen. I have never done roles like that because I feel uncomfortable. I just say no. I have rejected many big films for this reason. But I am okay to give it up. That is my personal boundary and I don’t want to cross it. That is an internal thing for me.”

Earlier, actor Benedict Garrett, who is also part of ‘Toxic’, reacted to those targeting Kiara Advani for appearing in ‘bold’ scenes in Geethu Mohandas’

Aggarwal responded to a question about why female actors are often criticised for doing ‘bold’ scenes, particularly after marriage

film. “I’ve seen people praising Yash, filling his comments with fire emojis and saying how amazing he looks. But when it comes to Kiara Advani, she’s become the butt of jokes. People are saying things like, ‘Oh, she only just got married... She’s a mother... She’s on a honeymoon with Yash instead of Sidharth Malhotra (Kiara’s husband)’. Seriously,” he said in a video posted on ‘Instagram’.

The actor continued, “Yash is also married and he also has children. So why is only the woman getting the abuse, while the man apparently gets the applause? Listen, here’s the reality check. They are actors. Their job is to act... To portray characters... To make you believe that they are in love, even when they’re not. Their job is to tell stories that reflect the human experience.” AGENCIES

THE PRINCESS DIARIES 3

Anne Hathaway shares updates on the film

She said the makers had a story breakthrough and are ‘moving in the right direction’

LOS ANGELES: Hollywood actress Anne Hathaway said the makers of Disney’s ‘The Princess Diaries 3’ had a story breakthrough and are ‘moving in the right direction’.

Hathaway said the script was scrapped, but now the makers are on the right track. “I can say I think we had a story breakthrough. I think we are moving in the right direction. The script that we were working on, we kind of had to start over with this new direction, which is not the update I think anybody wants, but we all feel really good that this is gonna be the one,” the actor, who is currently promoting her latest film ‘The Odyssey’, said on SiriusXM’s ‘Radio Andy’.

The actress, who is expecting her third child, said she is unsure when she will start working on ‘The Princess Diaries 3’. “I’m busy making baby number three and that has

sort of taken the place of knowing when exactly I can make ‘Princess Diaries 3’,” she said.

The first film of ‘The Princess Diaries’ (2001) franchise was directed by Garry Marshall and featured the actor in the role of Mia Thermopolis, whose life turns upside down after she discovers she is the sole heir to the throne of Genovia. It also

starred Julie Andrews and Hector Elizondo alongside Hathaway.

Another instalment released in 2004 and followed a 21-year-old Princeton graduate, Princess Thermopolis, returning to the kingdom of Genovia to be crowned, only to discover a strict legal loophole: an unmarried woman cannot be crowned Queen. It was also directed by Marshall and featured Andrews and Chris Pine in pivotal roles.

‘The Princess Diaries 3’ is directed by Adele Lim. PFI

The actress, who is expecting her third child, said she is unsure when she will start working on the film



‘THE ODYSSEY’ STORMS THE BOX OFFICE WITH A USD 264.1 MILLION GLOBAL DEBUT

It has notched an even better debut than ‘Oppenheimer’, marking Christopher Nolan’s best opening since 2012’s ‘The Dark Knight Rises’

Christopher Nolan’s ‘The Odyssey’ launched with an estimated 124.5 million dollars in domestic ticket sales and another 139.6 million dollars from overseas, notching an even better debut than ‘Oppenheimer’ and marking the filmmaker’s best opening since 2012’s ‘The Dark Knight Rises’.

Nolan flexed his singular box-office might with a global debut unlike any other. Few filmmakers alive could pull off a starry, big-budget adaptation of Homer’s epic poem. But in Hollywood, where intellectual property rights rule most hits, Nolan turned one of the world’s oldest works of literature into an unlikely summer blockbuster.

The ‘Universal’ production was no small gamble on Nolan, coming off the 2023 best picture-winning ‘Oppenheimer’. With a production budget of 250 million dollars, it’s among the most expensive R-rated movies ever made. ‘Universal’ is spending some 125 million dollars to market it.

But no behind-the-camera name turns out audiences more than Nolan’s. So great was the hype on ‘The Odyssey’



that IMAX put tickets on sale for some 70 mm showtimes a full year in advance. To satisfy the extraordinary demand for Nolan’s preferred format, IMAX 70 mm, some theatres added midnight and 3 am screenings and sold them out.

“It’s incredibly rewarding to see the palpable excitement in theatres this weekend,” said Jim Orr, head of domestic distribution for ‘Universal’. “Nolan has crafted an epic adventure. It’s on a scale that audiences have responded to extraordinarily well.”

Billed as Nolan’s first fea-



Nolan flexed his singular box-office might with a global debut unlike any other

ture shot entirely with IMAX cameras, the format drove a huge slice of ticket sales. That included 29.6 million dollars domestically on IMAX and 51.8 million dollars globally, leading to the company’s best weekend ever. IMAX is dedicating its screens entirely to ‘The Odyssey’ for three weeks. Though only 41 IMAX screens can screen ‘The Odyssey’ in 70 mm, they accounted for 6.3 mil-

lion dollars in ticket sales. “The IMAX of it all helped turn it from not only a blockbuster, but a global cultural event,” said Rich Gelfond, chief executive of IMAX. “We have tickets on sale for week five in some theatres and some of them have already sold out.”

Since the pandemic, Nolan has been at the forefront of reviving cinemas. His ‘Tenet’ was one of the first big releases

to wade back into theatres in 2020. Three years later, ‘Oppenheimer’ and Greta Gerwig’s ‘Barbie’ combined to create arguably the movies’ signature moment of the decade. ‘Oppenheimer’ ultimately grossed 975 million dollars worldwide.

‘The Odyssey’ arrived in theatres during Hollywood’s best summer since 2019. Ticket sales are running 10.4 per cent ahead of last year, according to ‘Rentrak’. The industry is expecting the first 10 billion dollars year at the domestic box office since the pandemic.

The only question for ‘The Odyssey’ will be how front-loaded it is, given that many moviegoers have had this weekend circled for months. The film faced no new release competition over the weekend and it won’t next weekend, either.

Gelfond said that presales for the movie’s second weekend would rank among their 10 best presales, proof that many moviegoers are waiting to see the film in their preferred format. IMAX 70mm screenings, he said, are largely sold out for the next month, except for some front row seats.

“Christopher Nolan and

Tom Cruise may be the two most high-profile ambassadors for the big-screen experience,” said Paul Dergarabedian, head of marketplace trends for ‘Rentrak’. “Nolan is a director who’s a star as much as any movie star in front of the camera.”

The audience for ‘The Odyssey’ was notably male, accounting for 59 per cent of tickets sold. But Orr said moviegoers were otherwise ‘ridiculously broad’, playing across demographics and geography.

“It’s delivering for a 17-year-old dude and it’s delivering for a female that’s 55 and up,” said Orr. “It points to what I’m convinced will be a very long, very successful run throughout not only the rest of the summer but into the fall, too.”

The next movie to pose any competition, ironically, also stars Tom Holland and Zendaya: Sony’s ‘Spider-Man: Brand New Day’ on July 31.

‘The Odyssey’ stars Matt Damon as Odysseus and features Holland as his son, Telemachus; Anne Hathaway as Penelope; Zendaya as Athena; Robert Pattinson as the suitor Antinous and Charlize Theron as the sea nymph Calypso. AGENCIES

